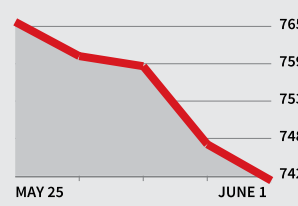


# the hindu businessline

**SENSEX** 74267.34 (-508.40)



**IN FOCUS**

|                       | LATEST    | CHANGE  |
|-----------------------|-----------|---------|
| Nifty 50              | 23382.60  | -165.15 |
| P/E Ratio (Sensex)    | 20.10     | 0       |
| US Dollar (in ₹)      | 94.99     | -0.01   |
| Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹) | 154913.00 | -923    |
| Silver 1 kg (in ₹)    | 263250.00 | -100    |

## MONSOON DAMPENER.

**Govt cuts kharif fertilizer demand estimate as the IMD forecasts below normal South-West monsoon **p10****



## GAME ON.

**Zee Entertainment bags FIFA World Cup broadcasting rights from 2026 to 2034 **p12****

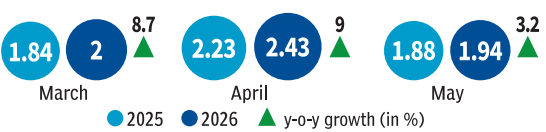
BENGALURU - CHENNAI - COIMBATORE - HUBBALLI - HYDERABAD - KOCHI - KOLKATA - MADURAI - MALAPPURAM - MANGALURU - MUMBAI - NOIDA - THIRUVANANTHAPURAM - TIRUCHIRAPALLI - VIJAYAWADA - VISAKHAPATNAM

Regd. TN/ARD/14/2012-2014, RNI No. 55320/94

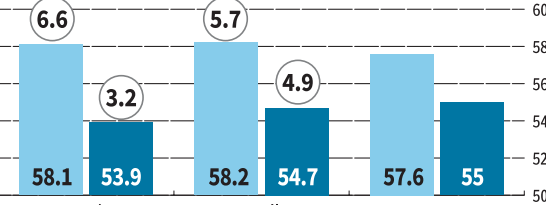
## Growth indicators in green

Various high-frequency economic indicators released on Monday showed that the economy is resilient and domestic demand is picking up. While GST collections grew to ₹1.94 lakh crore in May, showing a growth of 3.2 per cent, PMI manufacturing posted 55 in May, above the April reading of 54.7, indicating the strongest improvement in the sector's health in three months.

**Gross GST collections up by 3.2 per cent** (in ₹ lakh cr)



## Indicators of industrial and manufacturing health look up month-on-month



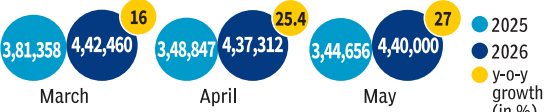
\*New series with base year 2022-23 Source: Official release, S&P Global

## Average daily value of UPI transactions cross the ₹1-lakh crore mark in May 2026

| Month | Volume (mn) | Avg daily volume (mn) | Value (in ₹ cr) | Avg daily value (in ₹ cr) |
|-------|-------------|-----------------------|-----------------|---------------------------|
| March | 22,641      | 730                   | 29,52,542       | 95,243                    |
| April | 22,348      | 745                   | 28,80,846       | 96,028                    |
| May*  | 15,215      | 761                   | 20,18,332       | 1,00,917                  |

\*Month-to-day, as of May 20, 2026 Source: NPCI

## Sales of all passenger vehicles rise by 27 per cent in May, year-on-year



\*May 2026 figures are estimates Source: Company disclosures

Compiled by **Sourashis Banerjee**

# India may roll back some FTA concessions over UK steel curbs

**TIT-FOR-TAT.** Scotch whisky may be on top of India list; Goyal, UK counterpart Kyle to discuss trade deal issues today

**Amiti Sen**  
New Delhi



India is weighing the option of withdrawing some market access concessions offered to the UK for certain items, such as Scotch whisky, under the bilateral FTA signed last year because of new steel restrictions imposed by Britain that would hit exports from the country, sources said.

“India needs to rebalance the FTA as the UK has come up with new import restrictions on steel. The options that we are looking at include withdrawal of certain tariff concessions on British exports to India, including Scotch whisky,” a person tracking the development told *businessline*.

## IMPORT QUOTA, CBAM

New Delhi's concerns on UK steel import quotas and issues related to the Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (CBAM) are likely to be taken up for discussion in a meeting between Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal and

UK Secretary of State for Business and Trade Peter Kyle on Tuesday.

“Right now, India is more bothered about the steel import quotas as the new measure will be applicable from next month. Carbon levies on export of identified items, such as steel and aluminium and fertilizers, are still some months away. But those need to be discussed too,” the source said.

The UK has proposed steel safeguard measures, under which tariff-free import quotas will be slashed from July 1 and duties on shipments exceeding the quota will be near-doubled to 50 per cent. India's export of iron and steel to the UK in FY26 was around \$900 mil-

lion, much of which could be hit by the UK's new steel safeguard measures, per industry estimates.

The India-UK FTA, formally called the Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement (CETA), concluded in July 2025 but is yet to be implemented.

## RE-BALANCING

If the UK does not respond positively to India's concerns, New Delhi could take “rebalancing” measures, withdrawing certain benefits as a tit-for-tat measure.

“The UK gained big concessions for Scotch whisky under the CETA with India agreeing to halve import duties on whisky and gin from 150 per cent to 75 per cent when the agreement comes into force, bringing it down further to 40 per cent over a 10-year period. India could consider reducing concessions here,” the source said.

There are other items, too, on which concessions could be rolled back and a final decision will be taken after consultations, the source added.

# ECLGS 5.0: 2.63 lakh apply; over ₹35,000 cr sanctioned to units hit by Gulf crisis

**Shishir Sinha**  
New Delhi

The Centre on Monday said that over 2.63 lakh applications for loans of ₹1.71 lakh crore have been received under the latest version of Emergency Credit Line Guarantee Scheme (ECLGS 5.0). The data are up to May 29.

At an inter-ministerial briefing on West Asia, Manoj Ayyappan, Joint Secretary in the Financial Services Department, said of the applications received, 79,950 had been sanctioned. On these, ₹35,194 crore had already been sanctioned.

Based on the sanctions, the guarantee applications were flowing in, and ₹15,720 crore worth of guarantees had also been issued, he said.

On May 5, the Cabinet approved ECLGS 5.0, under which the National Credit Guarantee Trustee Company Ltd will provide credit guarantee coverage of 100 per cent for MSMEs and 90 per cent for non-MSMEs, including airlines, to member lending institutions.

The scheme covers defaults on additional credit extended to eligible borrowers to help them manage short-term liquidity mismatches arising from the

West Asia crisis.

## KEY CRITERIA

According to a government statement, the scheme applies to MSMEs and non-MSMEs with existing working capital limits and scheduled passenger airlines with outstanding credit facilities as of March 31, 2026, provided their accounts are classified as standard.

The scheme carries no guarantee fee and allows additional credit of up to 20 per cent of peak working capital utilised in Q4FY26, capped at ₹100 crore. For airlines, the limit is up to 100 per cent, subject to a cap of ₹1,500 crore per borrower and specified conditions.

The scheme aims to enable businesses to tide over the challenges arising from the West Asia conflict. Additionally, this is expected to help businesses maintain their operations, protect jobs and sustain supply chains.

The scheme is a major step to help businesses, particularly MSMEs and the airline sector get their additional working capital needs from banks and financial institutions. By providing timely liquidity, the scheme will sustain the businesses and prevent job losses, the statement added.

## QUICKLY.

**AS DIPLOMACY DRAGS...**  
Iran and US trade strikes, Kuwait comes under fire



Iran and the US carried out strikes on military targets, and each accused the other of aggression as diplomatic efforts to end the war drag on. The US military said it had, at the weekend, struck Iranian air defences, a ground control station and two drones that were threatening ships after “aggressive Iranian actions”. Kuwait activated air defences and denounced Iranian missile and drone attacks. **p9**

## AI PUSH

**Indian IT ups R&D spend, still trails global Big Tech**

**Bengaluru:** Even as Indian IT services firms step up spending on research and development, their investments remain modest compared with their global technology peers. While Infosys increased its standalone R&D expenditure to ₹1,093 crore in FY26 from ₹850 crore a year earlier, TCS reported standalone R&D and innovation expenditure of ₹2,814 crore in FY26, representing 1.3 per cent of total turnover. **p9**



# Something good is waking up...

www.suzlon.com



QUICKLY.

Wipro to acquire 20% stake in Aggne Global



**Bengaluru:** Wipro on Monday said it will acquire an additional 20 per cent stake in Aggne Global Inc for \$28.5 million, increasing its shareholding in the insurance technology specialist to 80 per cent. In a regulatory filing, the company said the transaction, which is expected to close by June 5, will be carried out through its subsidiary, Wipro IT Services, LLC. The purchase consideration of \$28.5 million is attributable to Aggne Global Inc and is subject to customary closing adjustments. **OUR BUREAU**

Simple Energy secures ₹250 crore funding

**Mumbai:** IPO-bound two-wheeler maker Simple Energy has secured ₹250 crore in its Series B funding round, comprising both debt and equity for scaling up production, including manufacturing and capacity expansion. The round was led by the family office of Arokiaswamy Velumani, along with Founder and CEO of Simple Energy Suhas Rajkumar, and Co-founder and CFO Ankit Gupta, said Simple Energy. The debt partners include HDFC Bank and Capitar Ventures, with other NBFCs bringing in ₹123 crore. **PTI**

## Fuel costs pull ICE 2W sales down 8.6% in May

Amit Vijay Mohile  
Mumbai

Rising fuel costs and operating economics are beginning to reshape buying behaviour in India's two-wheeler market, creating a sharp paradox.

Overall industry sales continued to grow 7.4 per cent year-on-year in May 2026 even as petrol-powered vehicle sales fell 8.6 per cent sequentially, with electric vehicles increasingly offsetting the slowdown in conventional scooters and motorcycles, according to Vahan retail data.

Overall two-wheeler registrations stood at 18.43 lakh units in May compared with 17.15 lakh units a year earlier, although sales declined from 19.87 lakh units in April. ICE two-wheelers, which still account for over 90 per cent of total industry volumes, grew just 3.9 per cent year-on-year to 16.72 lakh units from 16.10 lakh units in May 2025, while falling 8.6 per cent month-on-month from 18.29 lakh units in April.

In contrast, EV two-wheeler registrations surged 62.5 per cent y-o-y to 1.70 lakh units from 1.04 lakh units a year earlier, and also rose 8.4 per cent sequentially from 1.57 lakh units in April, indicating that the broader market slowdown was concentrated almost entirely in petrol-powered vehicles.

### GROWTH OF EVs

The paradox is becoming sharper at the manufacturers' level, where several companies seeing slowdown in their petrol-powered portfolios are simultaneously witnessing rapid growth in EVs.

Hero MotoCorp's ICE

# May e4W registrations up 82% on pricey fuel & new launches

**GOING ELECTRIC.** Monthly registrations averaged 25,000 units since March: Vahan data

T E Raja Simhan  
Chennai

Registrations of electric four-wheelers (e4W) rose in May 2026, driven by rising fuel prices, a wave of new model launches and improving consumer confidence in electric mobility.

Registrations rose 82 per cent year-on-year in May 2026 to 25,509 units, from 14,006 units in the same month last year, according to Vahan data collated as of 9 am on June 1.

On a month-on-month basis, registrations increased 14 per cent, from 22,405 units in April.

According to Crisil estimates, EV penetration — as a share of total passenger vehicle registrations — has moved steadily higher, from 4.9 per cent in March 2026 to 6.4 per cent the following month and to 6.9 per cent in May.

### MARKET FACTORS

Industry experts said the surge reflects a combination of economic and market factors. The steep increase in petrol and diesel prices in May widened the running-cost advantage of electric vehicles, while a growing range of products across segments, particularly SUVs, attracted a broader set of buyers. The entry of new

Electric four-wheeler registration (in units)

| Company                          | May 2025 | Mkt share (%) | May 2026 | Mkt share (%) |
|----------------------------------|----------|---------------|----------|---------------|
| Tata Passenger Electric Mobility | 4,760    | 34.0          | 9,995    | 39.2          |
| Mahindra Electric Automobile     | 2,634    | 18.8          | 5,744    | 22.5          |
| JSW MG Motor                     | 4,427    | 31.6          | 4,905    | 19.2          |
| Maruti Suzuki India              | -        | -             | 1,576    | 6.2           |
| VinFast Auto India               | -        | -             | 923      | 3.6           |

manufacturers and continuous product launches have also expanded consumer choice and boosted market visibility

Since March 2026, monthly registrations have averaged around 25,000 units, compared to roughly 17,300 units through most of FY26, a jump of close to 45 per cent, pointing to a meaningful shift, said Poonam Upadhyay, Director, Crisil Ratings. Fuel costs have been a key factor.

Petrol and diesel prices rose by a cumulative ₹7.50 per litre across four revisions in May alone, and with global crude supply remaining uncertain, direction of fuel prices is unlikely to ease in the near term, she said.

The recent hikes have widened the running cost advantage of EVs further, and

buyers in cities with reasonable charging infrastructure are increasingly factoring that in. OEMs expanding into the mid-SUV segment have also brought more buyers into the consideration set.

Gaurav Vangaal of S&P Global Mobility said a meaningful part of India's e4W volume expansion can be attributed to the growing cadence of new launches continuously adding incremental units to the segment.

Each new model entry brings its own buyer cohort, and collectively these additions are stacking up into visible growth, he said.

"The segment's long-term health will depend on whether these incremental launches are seeding a loyal, repeat buyer base, or simply

redistributing the same early-adopter pool across a wider set of nameplates," he said.

### IN THE LEAD

Tata Passenger Electric Mobility retained its leadership position in the electric car segment, while Mahindra Electric Automobile emerged as the fastest-growing major player in the segment.

Tata recorded 9,995 units in May. The company more than doubled its sales from 4,760 units in the corresponding month last year, registering a growth of nearly 110 per cent.

Mahindra recorded sales of 5,744 units in May, representing a growth of 118 per cent. Its market share improved to 22.52 per cent from 18.81 per cent a year earlier, although it was marginally lower than the 23.09 per cent recorded in April.

JSW MG Motor sold 4,905 units in May, up 10.8 per cent from 4,427 units in May 2025. Despite the increase in volumes, its market share declined significantly to 19.23 per cent from 31.61 per cent a year ago, indicating stronger growth by rivals.

Maruti Suzuki India sold 1,576 units in May, accounting for a 6.18 per cent market share. The company had sold 1,222 units in April when its share stood at 5.45 per cent.

## Despite disturbance in West Asia, carmakers see high demand in May

S Ronendra Singh  
New Delhi

Driven by sustained demand and new launches, automobile companies remained largely unaffected by geopolitical tensions and reported positive year-on-year (y-o-y) growth in domestic sales in May.

### PREVIOUS RECORD

Maruti Suzuki India (MSIL) reported that its wholesales (dispatches to dealers) surpassed the previous all-time high record set in April (2.39 lakh units) by selling over 2.42 lakh units in May.

According to industry executives, PV sales have grown 26 per cent y-o-y at around 4.4 lakh units in May, compared with 3.51 lakh units in May 2025. In the domestic market, MSIL recorded the highest-ever monthly dispatches of 1,90,337 units during the month, a jump of 40 per cent y-o-y, compared with 1,35,962 units in May 2025.

"All segments (mini, compact, midsize, utility vehicles and vans) registered y-o-y growth during the month and we have also recorded highest-ever CNG sales of around 78,000 units. We have a network stock of around 17 days and pending bookings of around 1.5 lakh vehicles," said Partho Banerjee, Senior Executive Officer, Marketing & Sales, MSIL.

### RURAL SALES

He said rural sales have also seen a growth of 55 per cent y-o-y during the month and rural penetration to overall domestic sales have gone up to 53.2 per cent in May.

Tata Motors emerged as the second largest PV seller

### Auto sales

| Company                          | May 2026 | May 2025 | % change |
|----------------------------------|----------|----------|----------|
| <b>Passenger Vehicles</b>        |          |          |          |
| Maruti Suzuki India              | 1,90,337 | 1,35,962 | 40.0     |
| Tata Motors Passenger Vehicles   | 59,090   | 41,357   | 42.0     |
| M&M                              | 58,021   | 52,431   | 11.0     |
| Hyundai Motor India              | 47,837   | 43,861   | 9.0      |
| Toyota Kirloskar Motor           | 30,574   | 29,280   | 4.0      |
| Kia India                        | 27,586   | 22,315   | 23.6     |
| JSW MG Motor India               | 6,048    | 6,304    | -4.0     |
| Honda Cars India                 | 5,111    | 3,950    | 29.3     |
| Renault India                    | 4,113    | 2,502    | 64.3     |
| Nissan Motor India               | 2,948    | 1,354    | 117.7    |
| <b>Two-Wheelers</b>              |          |          |          |
| Hero MotoCorp                    | 536,784  | 488,997  | 9.77     |
| Honda Motorcycle & Scooter India | 4,59,611 | 4,17,250 | 10.0     |
| TVS Motor Company                | 3,84,565 | 3,09,287 | 24.3     |
| Bajaj Auto                       | 2,09,528 | 1,91,412 | 9.0      |
| Suzuki Motorcycle India          | 1,10,028 | 1,07,780 | 2.0      |
| Royal Enfield                    | 94,115   | 75,820   | 24.0     |

Source: Companies/Industry Sources

in May, dethroning Mahindra and Mahindra (M&M) from the position with domestic wholesales of 59,090 units, registering a growth of 42 per cent y-o-y as compared with 41,557 units in May 2025.

M&M reported a growth of 11 per cent y-o-y at 58,021 units in May against 52,431 units in the same month last year.

Hyundai Motor India Ltd (HMIL) also said its domestic wholesales grew 9 per cent y-o-y to 47,837 units in May, compared with 43,861 units in the same month last year.

"In the first two months (April and May) of FY27, HMIL witnessed domestic sales rise by 13 per cent to 99,739 units, compared to 88,235 units in the same period of FY26," said Tarun Garg, MD and CEO, HMIL.

Kia India also said it recor-

ded highest-ever May sales since inception, with wholesale volumes of 27,586 units, recording 23.6 per cent y-o-y growth over 22,315 units sold in May 2025.

"The continued strong demand for the new Seltos along with Sonet, coupled with the encouraging response to the Carens Clavis, Clavis EV and the MY26 Syros, helped us sustain our growth momentum. At the same time, recent initiatives like our Battery-as-a-Service programme are playing an important role in making electric mobility more accessible and practical for customers," said Atul Sood, Senior V-P, Sales & Marketing, Kia India.

Hector-maker JSW MG Motor India reported a decline of 4 per cent y-o-y to 6,048 units in May, compared with 6,304 units in May 2025.

## 'After PM's call to limit fossil fuel vehicles, demand up for CNG/EVs'

S Ronendra Singh  
New Delhi

Following Prime Minister Narendra Modi's call to use alternative modes of transport such as EVs and CNG, the sales of these vehicles have grown sharply. May witnessed sales of around 78,000 units and two-fold growth in EV bookings, said Maruti Suzuki India Ltd.

"After the mandate given by our Prime Minister that we all need to focus more on EVs and CNG vehicles, we

are happy to share that we have been focusing on the CNG vehicles, and in May we recorded the highest-ever sales of 78,000 CNG vehicles. In EVs also, the bookings have increased two-fold after the announcement by the PM on May 11, and we are seeing healthy traction of our e-Vitara also," Partho Banerjee, Senior Executive Officer, Marketing & Sales, MSIL, told **businessline**.

He said Victoris has become the fastest vehicle to achieve 1 lakh sales in India

within nine months of launch. Targeted at Gen Z and youth, 40 per cent of the sales come from them, and 35 per cent of SUV sales come from first-time buyers.

According to Jato Dynamics, before Victoris it was Fronx by Maruti Suzuki that achieved 1 lakh sales in 10 months. Earlier, Tata Punch achieved the milestone in 11 months and Hyundai Grand i10 in 12 months.

"Victoris has been the fastest model to reach 1 lakh sales in just nine months — not just within the SUV seg-

ment but across all segments — and it has been certified by Jato Dynamics as well," Banerjee noted.

### TWO NEW PLANTS

On the growth of small cars and overall demand, he said the company was strained by production even after full utilisation of the existing plants, but after the opening up of two new plants — one each in Kharkhoda (Haryana) and Hansalpur (Gujarat) — the company has been able to supply vehicles on time. "We were

short of vehicles till March, but as soon as we started getting vehicles from the two new plants, we could sell over to our customers. But still we have pending bookings of 17 days with around 1.5 lakh units," Banerjee noted.

### FUEL PRICE HIKE

On fuel price hikes, he said consumers choose Maruti vehicles because they provide better mileage compared to the competitors.

"We are doing well in all our segments, not just a few

## Nifty-50 valuation faces test as global capital chases faster earnings growth

Sourashis Banerjee  
Chennai

India's benchmark Nifty 50 remains one of the most expensive major emerging market (EM) indices, despite posting some of the weakest earnings growth in 2026 — a combination that has coincided with one of the poorest market performances among its EM peers this year.

### DATA FOCUS.

A **businessline** analysis of data from Bloomberg as of May 29, 2026, shows that Nifty50 companies recorded year-to-date earnings growth of just 1.3 per cent, placing India ahead of only China's SHCOMP (-3.8 per cent) and Singapore's STI (-5.8 per cent) among the major emerging market indices tracked. Yet, Nifty continued to trade at a price-to-earnings (P/E) ratio of 19.88, the third-highest valuation in the group.

### EARNINGS MOMENTUM

The strongest earnings growth has come from the East Asian markets. South Korea's KOSPI posted a remarkable 56.1 per cent rise in earnings, while Taiwan's TWSE recorded growth of 19.5 per cent. Both markets also delivered exceptional returns to investors, with the KOSPI surging 96.7 per cent year-to-date and TWSE gaining 52.4 per cent.

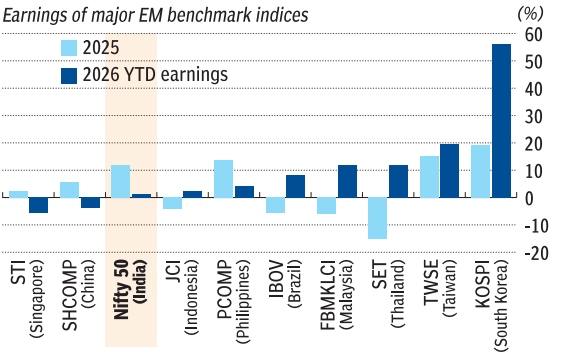
In South Korea, Samsung Electro-Mechanics saw its stock value multiply over seven times by May 29 from last year, driven by its dominance in AI server internal components and cooling infrastructure.

Meanwhile, semiconductor powerhouse SK Hynix crossed the historic \$1 trillion valuation mark on May 27 by leveraging a virtual monopoly on high-bandwidth memory (HBM) chips supplied directly to Nvidia.

In Taiwan, TSMC single-handedly commands nearly half of the TWSE's entire value, soaring to a massive \$1.9 trillion market capitalisation as the ultimate manufacturing bottleneck for every major tech giant, including Nvidia, AMD and Apple. Alongside it, MediaTek doubled its stock value via its premium Dimensity chip series — triggering a massive on-device generative AI smartphone upgrade

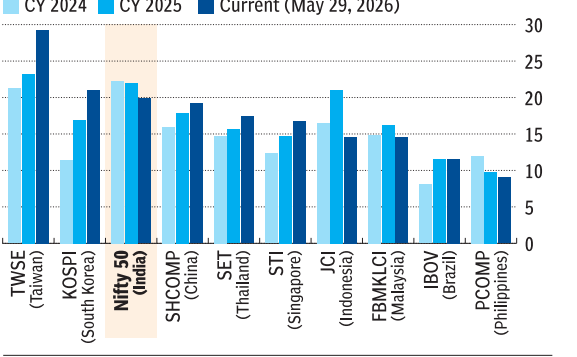
### Capital flows shift

India's Nifty 50 has one of the slowest earnings per share growth in 2026 among EM peers



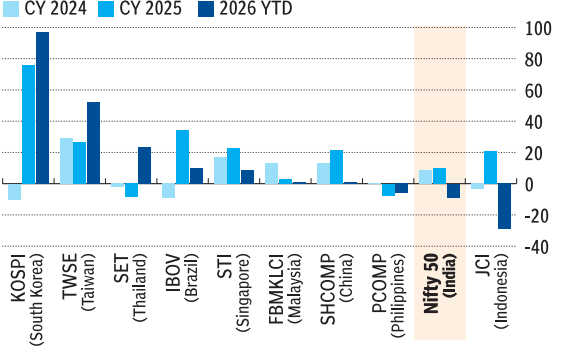
Yet Nifty 50 is still one of the most overvalued indices

Price-to-Earnings (P/E) ratio of major emerging markets (EM)



Nifty 50 returns are also among the lowest in 2026

Returns of major EM benchmark indices (in %)



Source: Bloomberg, as on May 29, 2pm (IST)

cycle — while expanding high-margin revenues through an EV-focused smart vehicle partnership with Nvidia. Other markets also outpaced India on the earnings front. Thailand's SET index reported earnings growth of 11.8 per cent, closely matched by Malaysia's FBKMLCI at 11.8 per cent, while Brazil's IBOV expanded earnings by 8.2 per cent.

### PROFIT GROWTH

The sharp divergence suggests that investors have increasingly rewarded markets where corporate profit growth has accelerated, particularly those linked to the global artificial intelligence

and semiconductor supply chain.

Despite modest earnings growth, India's valuation remains elevated. Only Taiwan, with a P/E ratio of 29.26, and South Korea, at 21.07, trade at higher multiples. China's SHCOMP follows closely at 19.18, while most other emerging market benchmarks trade at significantly lower valuations.

The contrast is particularly striking given that Taiwan and South Korea have paired higher valuations with substantially stronger earnings expansion and market returns.

With inputs from intern  
Deepac Nishant

## Fire at Mobis India to disrupt production at Hyundai Motors plant

Our Bureau  
Chennai

The fire at Mobis India Ltd manufacturing facility near Chennai on Sunday is expected to temporarily disrupt production at Hyundai Motor's plant, according to the automaker. A source said the exact duration of the disruption is not known.

In a statement, Hyundai Motor India said the affected Mobis facility supplies audio systems and certain other automotive components used in its vehicles. While the company did not disclose the extent of the damage or the financial impact, it acknowledged that the incident could affect production schedules in the short term.

"Alternative sourcing and supply continuity measures are being actively explored to minimise the operational impact," said Hyundai, adding that there is adequate vehicle inventory available across its dealer network to meet current customer demand.

No fatalities were reported in the incident.

### EXTENT OF DAMAGE

Hyundai said teams from both companies are working closely to assess the situation and determine the extent of damage at the Mobis plant.

According to sources, the fire is suspected to have originated from the soldering line in the assembly section

## Alternative sourcing and supply continuity measures are being actively explored to minimise the operational impact, said Hyundai

before spreading rapidly through the facility.

Multiple fire tenders were pressed into service to contain the blaze, with firefighting operations continuing until midnight.

Mobis India is a key supplier of automotive components to the carmaker in Tamil Nadu.

Industry observers noted that modern automotive manufacturing operates on lean inventory and just-in-time supply systems, making uninterrupted component supplies critical for maintaining production schedules. Hyundai, however, indicated that it is taking proactive steps to ensure continuity and limit disruption to vehicle output.

### businessline.

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QUICKLY.

Sanjay Lohiya assumes charge as DFS Secretary

**New Delhi:** Sanjay Lohiya on Monday assumed charge of the Secretary, Department of Financial Services (DFS), which administers various Acts related to the banking, insurance and pension sectors. Lohiya, an IAS of the 1994 batch officer, was serving as Special Secretary in the Department, the DFS said in a post on X. He succeeds M Nagaraju, who superannuated on May 31. **PTI**

IPMA seeks paper and paperboard in key list

**New Delhi:** The Indian Paper Manufacturers Association (IPMA) has urged the government to include paper and paperboard in the exclusion list of the Asean-India Trade in Goods Agreement to discourage predatory imports. IPMA has further stated that if the ongoing review of the India-Asean agreement fails to adequately address the fundamental asymmetries and long-standing concerns of Indian industry, and the government should consider invoking the termination clause of the agreement. **PTI**

# Factory output expanded by 4.9% in April despite economic challenges

**FIRST PRINT.** Manufacturing, electricity sectors showed stronger performance; experts warn of rising costs

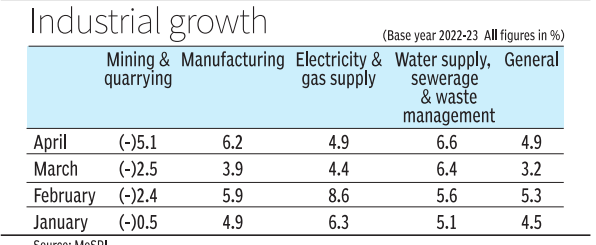
**Shishir Sinha**  
New Delhi

The first print of factory output growth based on the new series of Index of Industrial Production (IIP) with base year of 2022-23 recorded 4.9 per cent in April, Statistics Ministry reported on Monday.

It is lower than 5.7 per cent in the corresponding month of the last fiscal but higher than 3.2 per cent of the preceding month.

The growth rates of the four sectors — mining & quarrying, manufacturing, electricity & gas supply, water supply, sewerage & waste Management — for April 2026 stood at (-) 5.1 per cent, 6.2 per cent, 4.9 per cent and 6.6 per cent respectively, an official statement said.

Aastha Gudwani, India Chief Economist at Barclays, said the impact of West Asia conflict on industrial output appears minimal, limited to chemicals and allied sectors so far, in terms of the impact



on industrial output from the conflict (from energy price rises/shortages of inputs).

“We note that output in the manufacture of chemicals’ recovered somewhat in

April (to 0.4 per cent y-o-y from -4.9 per cent in March), which corroborates our view that peak shortages for industrial inputs (from gas and petrochemicals rationing) seen in March saw gradual

improvement in supply in April and May,” she said.

“Manufacture of coke & refined petroleum products was weak in April (-0.5 per cent y-o-y); however, the sector growth was generally subdued even prior to the conflict (February: -0.8 per cent, January: -0.3 per cent). As such, we would not entirely attribute the West Asia-related disruptions to output weakness here,” she added

**STRONGER GROWTH**

According to Dipti Deshpande, Principal Economist at Crisil Ltd, growth in April is driven by stronger growth in manufacturing and electricity production. Domestic demand held up, as evident from auto sales, retail credit, electricity demand and others despite headwinds from the West Asia conflict.

“Industrial production could remain subdued in the months ahead due to weaker global demand and supply chain disruptions. The larger

risk, though, is rising costs. The energy supply shock caused by the conflict in West Asia has morphed into a price shock, with the costs of fuel, transport and other imported inputs increasing,” she said.

The Ministry of Statistics & Programme Implementation (MoSPI) has revised the base year of the Index of Industrial Production (IIP) from 2011-12 to 2022-23.

The revised basket consists of 1,042 products mapped to 463 item groups, including 120 new item groups. This is the 10th revision of the base year for IIP. The first IIP was prepared with a base year 1937.

According to the MoSPI, the new IIP series provides greater granularity with separate indices for the generation of electricity through renewable and non-renewable, gas supply, fuel minerals, metallic minerals and non-metallic minerals, water supply, sewerage and waste management.

# GST collections cross ₹1.94 lakh cr in May on strong consumption

**Shishir Sinha**  
New Delhi

Collection from the Goods and Services Tax (GST) in May rose 3.2 per cent to over ₹1.94 lakh crore, the government said on Monday.

Collection in May is related to goods consumed and services availed in April. According to the GST portal, May 2025 GST revenue includes ₹10,000 crore of one-time payment made by a telecom operator for spectrum allocation. Adjusted for this one-time payment, gross GST revenue grew 9 per cent in May 2026 with domestic gross GST growth being 5 per cent.

**GOODS SECTORS**

According to government sources, growth was broad-based across good sectors. “Goods sector’s taxable supply grew 26.9 per cent in April, with positive growth recorded across all 27 commodity groups, confirming the breadth and durability of domestic demand,” a source said.

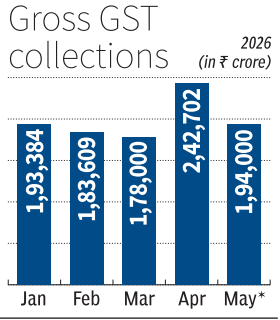
It rose to ₹40.10 lakh crore as against ₹31.61 lakh crore during the corresponding period of the last fiscal.

“Taxable supply is a good proxy for consumption in the economy. This growth is not concentrated in any single segment but spans agriculture, manufacturing, chemicals, metals, electronics and consumer goods simultaneously,” another source said.

Talking about the services sector, sources said taxable supply grew 22.2 per cent to over ₹11.50 lakh crore in April 2026-27, with every major service category registering positive growth, demonstrating structural resilience in domestic consumption.

“All major service categories are in positive growth territory,” the second source said, while adding that the strong showing in real estate, construction and transport further corroborates the investment and consumption narrative.

IGST on imports grew by a robust 20.2 per cent in May 2026, rising from ₹50,070 crore to ₹60,166 crore. This is the standout performer in the revenue mix. The bulk of this import growth is driven by raw materials and intermediate inputs that feed In-



dia’s industrial production chain.

Adjusted net GST collections (after refunds) have grown at 10.1 per cent. Refund disbursements have remained robust.

“Initiatives such as automated refunds for IDS and exports have ensured that legitimate refund claims are processed efficiently and without unnecessary delay,” the second source said.

According to Pratik Jain, Partner at Price Waterhouse, for April and May 26, collections show a robust 8.8 per cent growth on like to like basis. This is despite the steep rate cuts from September 2025 and geopolitical disruptions during the last couple of months. Imports and domestic consumption of products and services have expanded significantly, which shows our economic resilience, he said.

**SUPPLY CHAIN WOES**

“Given the increase in input costs due to supply chain issues, this might be a right time for the government to consider providing working capital support to industry by relaxing refund provisions with respect to input GST, which has been accumulating for many businesses,” he suggested.

Vivek Jalan, Partner at Tax Connect Advisory, also called for the urgent need for structural changes in GST. The upcoming GST Council meeting must address deepened inverted duty structures, particularly refunds on input services, which continue to distort competitiveness. “Bringing petroleum products under GST would be a landmark reform to rationalise tax incidence and reduce cascading effects. Equally important is easing the refund process with clear, transparent guidelines so that genuine businesses are not burdened by delays,” he said.

# Fiscal deficit doubles amid falling tax revenue, rising expenditures

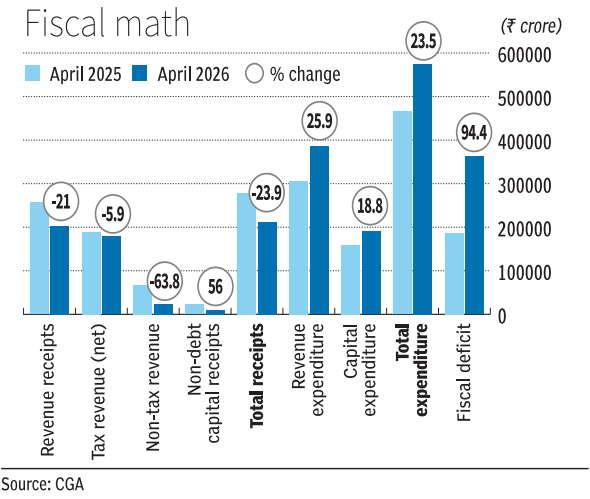
**Shishir Sinha**  
New Delhi

With a decline in tax revenue and higher expenditure, the government’s fiscal deficit in value terms nearly doubled in April, data released by Controller General of Accounts (CGA) showed on Monday. However, the government managed to close the fiscal year 2025-26 (FY26) with fiscal deficit of 4.4 per cent, in line with revised estimates.

Fiscal deficit is the gap between income and expenditure of the government

Data from CGA showed that while revenue receipts were down by over 21 per cent in April, expenditure rose by over 23 per cent in the said month. This resulted in fiscal deficit rising by around 94 per cent in April itself. As a percentage of budget estimates it was over 21 per cent as against over 11 per cent during corresponding period of last fiscal. Aditi Nayar, Chief Economist of ICRA, said while fiscal risks abound in the form of higher than budgeted fertilizer and LPG subsidies, and shortfalls in excise duty, corporate tax and dividend from the OMCs, a portion of the stress would be absorbed by higher import duty on gold and silver and the balance in the Economic Stabilisation Fund.

“While we estimate the slippage in the fiscal deficit at around 0.3 per cent of GDP relative to the FY2027 BE, the incremental borrowing requirement would be softened by the higher opening cash balance vis-a-vis the BE, partly benefitting from the overshooting in small



savings collections in FY2026,” she said.

**FISCAL DEFICIT**

The government has achieved its fiscal deficit target of 4.4 per cent of the GDP for 2025-26. The fiscal deficit for the previous financial year was estimated to be at ₹15,68,936 crore, which was revised down to ₹15,58,492 crore, as presented to Parliament in February by Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman.

As per the CGA data, the government managed to collect ₹33.42 lakh crore revenue, or 98.8 per cent of the revised Budget Estimates (RE). The central government’s expenditure during 2025-26 was ₹49.64 lakh crore, or 98.8 per cent of the RE.

According to DK Srivastava, Chief Policy Advisor, EY India, what is remarkable is that fiscal deficit has been lowered in absolute terms in 2025-26 to ₹15.2 lakh crore from ₹15.8 lakh crore in 2024-25. The adjustment required relative to GDP (2022-23 series) in 2025-26

was 60 basis points from a level of 5 per cent of GDP in 2024-25. This was achieved in spite of a lowering of Gol gross tax buoyancy in 2025-26 at 0.7 which occurred due to extensive Personal Income Tax and GST reforms.

“Going forward, meeting the 2026-27 fiscal deficit target of 4.3 per cent of GDP may be supported by the government’s continued focus on enhancing tax revenue buoyancy, to meet or exceed the budgeted level of 0.8,” Srivastava said.

While some moderation in union excise duty revenues is anticipated due to the partial absorption of global crude price increases, this also reflects a proactive approach to cushioning domestic impacts.

“In this context, the focus may remain on accelerating capital expenditure growth to at least 11.5 per cent in 2026-27 (as budgeted over the revised estimate), underscoring the government’s commitment to sustaining strong economic momentum,” Srivastava concluded.

# India, Myanmar to boost ties in critical minerals, rare earths

**Asian News International**  
New Delhi

India and Myanmar on Monday agreed to maintain close engagement on matters related to critical minerals and rare earths, with both countries aiming to take bilateral cooperation forward in these strategic sectors.

Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri, in a special briefing on the visit of Myanmar President U Min Aung Hlaing to India, said that issues related to critical minerals and rare earths were discussed between the two sides during the meeting between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and the Myanmar President. “Issues related to critical



Prime Minister Narendra Modi with Myanmar President U Min Aung Hlaing in New Delhi on Monday **PTI**

minerals and rare earths did come up during the discussion today. This has been a subject of bilateral discussion for some time. Today as well, there was an understanding that the two governments will continue to stay in touch on these issues

and take forward cooperation in these areas,” Misri said.

**CAPACITY BUILDING**

On defence collaboration, the Foreign Secretary highlighted that India’s partnership with Myanmar has largely focused on training, capacity building, and institution strengthening. He noted that the training of Myanmar troops is dedicated to UN Peacekeeping.

“This has been a focus for several years now, and mostly the defence cooperation with Myanmar focuses on training, capacity building, and institution building. A very important part of the training is in the context of UN Peacekeeping,” Misri said.

**Kerala Co-operative Milk Marketing Federation Ltd.**  
Milma Bhavan, Pattom P.O, Thiruvananthapuram-695004  
Phone: 0471 2786430, 429, e-mail: marketing@milma.com

**E-tender invite for doing EPR Compliance Activities from Reputed Agencies**

MILMA invites E-Tenders from eligible and experienced Service Providers/Agencies for the fulfillment of Extended Producer Responsibility (EPR) Compliance on behalf of KCMFM and its Regional Unions under the Plastic Waste Management Rules. Interested agencies with relevant experience and expertise may submit their bids through the e-tender portal on or before 05.06.2026, 2 pm in the prescribed Pro-forma mentioned in "Tenders" in the website, [www.milma.com](http://www.milma.com). Mob: 6282751067

Sd/- **MANAGING DIRECTOR**

**TATA TATA POWER**  
(Corporate Contracts Department)

The Tata Power Company Limited, Smart Center of Procurement Excellence, 2<sup>nd</sup> Floor, Sahar Receiving Station, Near Hotel Leela, Sahar Airport Road Andheri (E), Mumbai 400 059, Maharashtra, India (Board Line: 022-67173917) CIN: L28920MH1919PLC00567

**NOTICE INVITING TENDER (NIT)**

**The Tata Power Company Limited** invites tender from eligible vendors for the following tender package (Two-part Bidding) in Mumbai Distribution.

1) OLA for Civil Work in Birla Niwara DSS (Ref: CC27AAM004)

Interested bidders to submit Tender Fee and Authorization Letter up to 22.06.2026. For detailed NIT & Tender Document, please visit Tender section on website <https://www.tatapower.com>. Also, all future corrigendum's (if any), to the above tenders shall be informed on website <https://www.tatapower.com> only.

**KERALA INFRASTRUCTURE INVESTMENT FUND BOARD**  
(A Statutory Body under Finance Department, Government of Kerala)  
Finance and Administration Division  
website: [www.kiifb.org](http://www.kiifb.org)

**CORRIGENDUM**

With reference to the advertisement titled “Statement of Audited Standalone and Consolidated Financial Results for the Financial Year Ended March 31, 2026” published in Business Line on May 31, 2026, the words “Limited Review Report” appearing in the second paragraph shall be read as “Audit Report”.

All other contents of the advertisement remain unchanged.

**For Kerala Infrastructure Investment Fund Board**  
Sd/-  
Mini Antony  
Chief Executive Officer (In-Charge)

Place: Trivandrum  
Date: 01.06.2026

**KLM AXIVA FINVEST LIMITED**  
Registered Office: Plot No. 39, Door No. 8-13, 1st Floor, Ashoka Complex, Mythenpragam Colony, Gopalnagar X Road, Vaishal nagar P.O. Hyderabad Rangareddy - 500079  
CIN: U65913TG19971000693  
Email id: admin@klmaxiva.com  
website: [www.klmaxiva.com](http://www.klmaxiva.com)

[Regulation 52(8), read with regulation 52(4) of the Listing Regulations] (Rs. In Lakhs)

| Sl.No | Particulars                                                                                                                                 | Quarter ending March 31, 2026 | Quarter ending March 31, 2025 | Current year ended March 31, 2025 | Previous year ended March 31, 2025 |
|-------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------|-------------------------------|-----------------------------------|------------------------------------|
| 1     | Total Income from Operations                                                                                                                | 7,240.96                      | 8,829.64                      | 34,118.77                         | 34,065.74                          |
| 2     | Net Profit/ (Loss) for the period (before Tax, Exceptional and/ or Extraordinary items *)                                                   | -686.17                       | 496.40                        | 913.09                            | 1,980.79                           |
| 3     | Net Profit/ (Loss) for the period before tax (after Exceptional and/ or Extraordinary items *)                                              | -686.17                       | 496.40                        | 913.09                            | 1,980.79                           |
| 4     | Net Profit/ (Loss) for the period after tax (after Exceptional and/ or Extraordinary items) Exceptional and/ or Extraordinary items *)      | -313.10                       | 896.79                        | 886.08                            | 2,019.36                           |
| 5     | Total Comprehensive Income for the period (Comprising Profit/ (Loss) for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after tax)) | -377.08                       | 896.79                        | 822.10                            | 2,019.36                           |
| 6     | Paid up Equity Share Capital                                                                                                                | 26,858.14                     | 25,794.76                     | 26,858.14                         | 25,794.76                          |
| 7     | Reserves Including Securities Premium (Excluding Revaluation Reserve)                                                                       | -5,930.17                     | 983.71                        | -5,930.17                         | 983.71                             |
| 8     | Net worth                                                                                                                                   | 20,927.97                     | 26,778.47                     | 20,927.97                         | 26,778.47                          |
| 9     | Outstanding Debt                                                                                                                            | 1,56,462.44                   | 1,57,519.38                   | 1,56,462.44                       | 1,57,519.38                        |
| 10    | Outstanding Redeemable Preference Shares                                                                                                    | Nil                           | Nil                           | Nil                               | Nil                                |
| 11    | Debt Equity Ratio**                                                                                                                         | 7.48                          | 5.88                          | 7.48                              | 5.88                               |
| 12    | Earnings Per Share (Rs.) **                                                                                                                 |                               |                               |                                   |                                    |
| 12    | 1. Basic:                                                                                                                                   | -0.17                         | 0.35                          | 0.33                              | 0.85                               |
| 12    | 2. Diluted:                                                                                                                                 | -0.17                         | 0.35                          | 0.33                              | 0.85                               |
| 13    | Capital Redemption Reserve**                                                                                                                | NA                            | NA                            | NA                                | NA                                 |
| 14    | Debiture Redemption Reserve**                                                                                                               | NA                            | NA                            | NA                                | NA                                 |
| 15    | Debt Service Coverage Ratio**                                                                                                               | 0.34                          | 0.27                          | 0.34                              | 0.27                               |
| 16    | Interest Service Coverage Ratio**                                                                                                           | 1.05                          | 1.11                          | 1.05                              | 1.11                               |

\*Exceptional and/ or Extraordinary items adjusted in the Statement of Profit and Loss in accordance with Ind AS Rules/ AS Rules, whichever is applicable.  
\*\*The financial ratios except EPS being computed based on figures reported up to 31st March 2026

Other disclosures in compliance with Regulation 52(4) of the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 for the Quarter ended March 31, 2026

| Sl.No            | Particulars                                                   | Quarter Ended March 31, 2026 |
|------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------|
| 1                | Debt equity ratio                                             | 7.48                         |
| 2                | Debt service coverage ratio                                   | 0.34                         |
| 3                | Interest Coverage Ratio                                       | 1.05                         |
| 4                | Outstanding redeemable preference shares (Quantity and Value) | Nil                          |
| 5                | Capital redemption reserve/Debiture redemption reserve        | Nil                          |
| 6                | Net worth (Excl. revaluation reserve) for the year ended      | 20,927.97                    |
| 7                | Net profit /loss after tax for the quarter ended              | -377.08                      |
| 8                | Earnings Per Share (Basic & Diluted)                          | 0.33                         |
| 9                | Current Ratio                                                 | 2.08                         |
| 10               | Long term debt to working capital                             | 2.24                         |
| 11               | Bad debts to account receivable ratio                         | 0.33                         |
| 12               | Current liability ratio                                       | 0.37                         |
| 13               | Total debt to total assets                                    | 0.88                         |
| 14               | Debtors turnover                                              | Nil                          |
| 15               | Inventory turnover                                            | Nil                          |
| 16               | Operating Margin (%)                                          | 2.68%                        |
| 17               | Net profit Margin (%)                                         | 2.60%                        |
| 18               | Sector specific equivalent ratios, as applicable              |                              |
| a. CRAR (Tier I) |                                                               | 12.98%                       |
| b. GNPA          |                                                               | 3.07%                        |
| c. NNPA          |                                                               | 2.11%                        |

a) The above is an extract of the detailed format of quarterly/ annual financial results filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 52 of the LODR Regulations. The full format of the quarterly/ annual financial results is available on the websites of the Stock exchange(s) ([www.bseindia.com](http://www.bseindia.com)) and the listed entity (<http://www.klmaxiva.com/>)  
b) The financial ratios presented being computed based on figures reported up to 31st March 2026

For KLM Axiva Finvest Limited  
Sd/-  
Shibu Thekkumpurath Varghese  
Whole-Time Director  
(DIN: 02079917)

Date: 29-05-2026  
Place: Ernakulam



# Market for charity

Reform of social stock exchanges, a work in progress

**S**ocial stock exchanges (SSE), launched in the second half of FY23, have been in a comatose state. In a bid to give them a leg up, the Centre last week allowed companies to invest up to 10 per cent of the funds earmarked for corporate social responsibility (CSR) activities in zero coupon zero principal (ZCZP) bonds. ZCZP bonds are issued by non-profits to raise funds through the SSEs. While around 170 non-profit organisations are registered with the exchanges, less than 10 per cent have made issuances so far.

There have been just 16 issuances raising around ₹42 crore. The new rules are expected to release ₹3,000 crore annually from corporate coffers. This is all very well, provided the supply of ZCZP bonds too picks up. The potential demand for such instruments is not a concern. The Companies Act mandates that at least 2 per cent of average net profits recorded during the preceding three financial years should be set aside for CSR projects. This has resulted in more than ₹30,000 crore being available every year for projects linked to education, health, environment sustainability, rural development and so on. Under the new rules, companies in search of credible organisations or projects to spend their funds can buy into ZCZP bonds on social stock exchanges. Unspent CSR funds of BSE 200 companies had amounted to ₹1,920 crore in FY25 and ₹1,708 crore in FY24. But the supply of investible instruments must pick up. Recently, SEBI had allowed non-profits to remain registered with exchanges even if they do not make any issuances for three years, extending the timeline from two years earlier. SEBI had also reduced minimum subscription in ZCZP issuances from 75 per cent to 50 per cent. But besides these, SEBI must review the rules it has set out for non-profits — regarding eligibility criteria, annual disclosures, annual spends, audits and annual impact disclosures. In a bid to enhance credibility and transparency, SEBI may have laid down rules that are too onerous for small non-profits. Smaller non-profits in genuine need for funds are possibly discouraged from approaching this platform. A discussion with registered non-profits on their hardships could lead the way for another constructive set of reforms.

SSE set up by SEBI is one of its kind globally. It is a government-led initiative — unlike other countries where private trusts and organisations alone run these platforms. SEBI has been trying to increase demand on the platform by reducing the minimum subscription for ZCZP bonds from ₹10,000 to ₹1,000 and reducing the minimum subscription in social impact funds (which invest on SSE) from ₹2 lakh to ₹1,000. This could allow more small investors to participate on these platforms. The regulatory framework for SSEs, has however done well to bar entities where diversion of funds or money laundering is possible. Political and religious organisations, and trade associations cannot raise funds through SSEs. Overall, a balance between accountability and autonomy is called for.

## POCKET



# External shocks and policy choices

**POLICY OPTIONS.** To counter the Hormuz blockade, a renewable energy push and more financial reforms are needed



ASHIMA GOYAL

**I**t is well-known that market over-reaction tends to raise risk spreads for emerging market economies (EMEs), when there is a global shock. Even so, the standard advice for EMEs continues to be to tighten further, take costs upfront and give special concessions for foreign investors. A report wants India to discourage mutual fund SIPs and raise interest rates so that stock markets crash enough to entice foreign investors back in!

But this does not factor in how India has changed and the nuances of the policy combination that delivered high growth and low inflation in the post pandemic period. In a nutshell, India has much more diversity, buffers and substitution ability to counter adverse shocks today.

The policy combination that worked was to look through transient shocks, give temporary and targeted help, pass through if shocks were persistent but moderate as much as possible, while fast tracking reforms that reduce vulnerability. For example, deeper markets with more domestic participation are what prevent the tail wagging the dog,

**REACTING TO PERSISTENCE** Markets misinterpreted the PM's appeal as indicating serious problems. But it was only a recognition that the Middle-East logjam is turning out to be longer lasting. That does not, however, mean it is going to be permanent.

When the Ukraine conflict first broke out, oil prices remained high for one year, peaking at 122, which deflated was a real value of 77. The fall in GDP growth and rise in inflation was about 2 per cent each, but the next year we were back to 9 per cent growth with inflation again in the tolerance band.

The Hormuz blockade has reduced other vital supplies but it could end sooner. The world finds alternatives and there are those who believe Hormuz will become irrelevant if blockages last a year. India itself is investing in gasification of coal, a gas pipeline from Oman and acquiring oil and gas reserves in the UAE beyond Hormuz.

Oil producing countries do not like high prices since they know then alternatives to oil become attractive. Oil futures are also fluctuating but remain below \$100. They even touched \$70 recently. A growth-inflation cost of about 1 per cent is realistic if shortages



**TAX BURDEN.** Excise duties on petro products are among the highest globally GETTY IMAGES

last for six months. Demands for a full pass through are growing but uncertainty is still there. Moreover, extreme policies are better avoided. Oil OMCs have said to have lost one year's profits but domestic oil prices were unchanged for four years — they made excess profits when prices were \$70 and below for more than a year, but they did not decrease prices. Their pass through, as well as government excise cuts are used in a counter-cyclical fashion to smooth oil prices for domestic consumers. And the taxes paid by Indian oil users remain one of the highest in the world — which is sufficient inducement to economize use.

Economists are also worried about a rise in fiscal deficits, but the FRBM reset allows a 0.5 countercyclical rise in fiscal deficits. The government has earned countercyclical space by bringing deficits down after the pandemic. Very few countries have done that.

The ideas of burden sharing, countercyclical deficits, stabilisation funds are all meant to enable moderation of external shocks on the economy. Post-pandemic experience shows it can be done and is productive to do so.

**PUSHING REFORM** Further green substitution possibilities can be accelerated using the crisis to

**This is the opportunity to drastically cut fertilizer and food subsidies by raising prices and shifting to direct benefit transfers. Basic food kitchens in cities can substitute free food**

overcome political resistance. Already a number of hitherto intractable steps have been taken. Our energy intensity continues to fall.

The PM's seven appeals add to the list of policies available, helping avoid over-reliance on market prices. Prices have been raised, but more of a switch to less import intensive consumption and processes will save forex, increase domestic demand and lower impact on consumer wallets. Commentary focuses on extrinsic motivation but intrinsic motivation through a larger and common purpose can be extremely powerful. During the pandemic industry cut costs and worked with the government to mitigate effects. People say fight the fire today, but the more intelligent will use today's fire to prevent fires tomorrow, raising growth potential.

Other types of policies, however, are also required to make the appeals effective and are part of essential reform to reach growth objectives. Monetary incentives need to supplement the appeals. Prices of oil products are being raised. This is the opportunity to drastically cut fertilizer and food subsidies by raising prices and shifting to direct benefit transfers. Basic food kitchens in cities can substitute free food. Never waste a crisis!

Rooftop solar can be further incentivised and integrated into power distribution. Improving last mile connectivity will increase the use of public transport. Coordination across ministries and States should be enabled and successful examples highlighted.

**LET THE RUPEE SINK?** Pro-market analysts also want the rupee to be let go. But depreciation begets depreciation. Large depreciation since

the last year has not improved matters. Having fallen to a real value it last touched during the taper tantrum the rupee is seriously misaligned. Then also RBI hands off approach and communication that forex markets are too large to intervene led the rupee to sink. Then they had to come in with heavy market restrictions that set back market development. In volatile times it would be more effective for the RBI to buy-sell daily without damping market volatility as much as it did in 2023. Then expectations of one-way movements and panic hedging can be avoided.

The over-depreciation will correct as it always has after past crises. This incident is no different. It is only prolonged because oil shocks followed the Trump tariffs. With almost \$600 billion currency reserves accumulated with a BoP surplus in 29 of the 35 years after liberalisation, buffers are strong, and will be rebuilt again in future.

There is no need to pay more to acquire another few billion. It is better to fast-track intended reforms — regulations on inflows can be simplified; tax-exemptions in investments through GIFT City made more transparent; rules eased for pension funds; swap lines with other central banks can be strengthened.

**OR RAISE INTEREST RATES?** The alternative call to raise interest rates undermines India's resilience and ability to counter shocks. It is the traditional fear driven EME tightening. The trilemma holds only at the fictional point of a fixed exchange rate and perfect capital mobility. There is always monetary policy autonomy to set repo rates under a flexible exchange rate and prudential capital flow management tools. The interest rate defence is not in the inflation targeting (IT) mandate.

Raising short-interest rates to defend the rupee failed in 2013 — it was other measures that worked. Repo rates were raised to implement IT in 2014 but only raised risk premia and hurt growth.

Developing the debt market requires transparency, credit enhancements, good corporate governance, two-way quotes and market-making, broader trading and repo to reduce risk spreads. China and US debt markets boomed with low, not high interest rates.

Rates should be raised only if inflation is expected to persistently rise above comfort levels. In current circumstances, a real policy rate between 0.5 and 1.5 is appropriate.

Oil price shocks are as unfair as the earlier discriminatory tariffs against India and should unleash the same energy to protect ourselves and our development objectives.

The writer is Professor Emeritus, IGIDR

# Railways splintered into too many zones

Creating more Railway zones does not ensure operational efficiency and infra. Empowering divisions is the way forward

Sudhanshu Mani

**O**n June 1, a cosmetic change took effect as the emblem of Indian Railways (IR) expanded from 17 stars to 18, marking the operationalisation of the South Coast Railway headquartered in Visakhapatnam. Yet this additional star is less a symbol of progress than an indictment of a growing trend: the systematic fragmentation of a national asset under the guise of decentralisation.

Dividing a transporter mandated to run long-distance passenger and freight trains across India into territorially fragmented entities shaped by political boundaries defies operational logic. IR is not merely a public enterprise; it is an arm of the Central Government whose *raison d'être* is seamless national transportation. That pan-India character is now steadily yielding to hyper-regionalism.

Post-Independence railway reorganisation was intentionally designed around a few large zones to preserve operational unity, economies of scale, and cohesive national coordination. For decades until the late 1990s, a lean zonal structure served effectively, barring the creation of South Central Railway by carving it out of

Southern and Central Railways. The first departure from this philosophy came in the late 1990s when politics overtook operational wisdom and the government approved seven new zones despite concerns that the move would strain railway finances through new headquarters, administrative behemoths, control centres and expanded bureaucracies. By 2003, the number of zones rose to 16, setting a dangerous precedent: zonal headquarters became political trophies.

**ZONES GALORE** UP received an additional zone in North Central Railway at Allahabad; Bihar got Hajipur; Odisha Bhubaneswar; Rajasthan Jaipur; MP Jabalpur; Chhattisgarh Bilaspur; and Karnataka Hobballi. Later, Kolkata Metro became the 17th zone and the new Visakhapatnam headquarters now marks the 18th. Today, only two major States, Gujarat and Kerala, remain without zonal headquarters.

Proponents of smaller zones argue that limited geographical span allows closer monitoring of operations, faster maintenance and emergency responses and stronger local economic and transport development. More zones create more senior administrative posts and the 1996 expansion accelerated promotions for railway executives. But



**RAILWAYS.** Fragmented approach ANIL KUMAR SASTRY

executive promotions cannot become a benchmark for national policy. The operational backbone of IR lies in its divisions, not zones. Divisions handle train operations, safety, crew management, traffic control, and emergencies. Zonal headquarters form an intermediate coordinating layer beneath the Railway Board. In an era of real-time digital monitoring, advanced analytics, and modern communication systems, the need for proliferating intermediate headquarters has diminished. Empowered divisions can well focus on local aspirations.

More zones do not generate additional track capacity, better punctuality, improved safety, or higher freight earnings. They merely multiply boundaries and bureaucracy. When existing geographies are repeatedly

sliced without any corresponding expansion of the physical network, the system suffers severe diseconomies of scale. Freight movement, the financial lifeline of IR, demands seamless long-distance operations.

As zones increasingly align with political boundaries, they become vulnerable to State-level pressures.

The political temptation to create more zones remains irresistible because each headquarters becomes a feather in a leader's cap.

If smaller administrative units are needed for better operational monitoring, the answer lies in empowering divisions, not multiplying zones. Empowerment means giving divisions clearly defined targets, adequate resources, and accountability, not merely delegation of operational and financial powers.

With its passenger and freight revenues consistently showing weak growth, the time has come to halt this expansionary impulse. We need rational consolidation of existing zones, removal of redundant bureaucratic layers, stronger divisional autonomy, and restoration of IR to what it was always meant to be: a unified, efficient, pan-India economic engine.

The writer is an Independent Consultant and retired GM of ICF

✉ **LETTERS TO EDITOR** Send your letters by email to [bleditor@thehindu.co.in](mailto:bleditor@thehindu.co.in) or by post to 'Letters to the Editor', The Hindu Business Line, Kasturi Buildings, 859-860, Anna Salai, Chennai 600002.

## Marking fiasco

This refers to 'CBSE admits that there are vulnerabilities in the evaluation portal, more than a week later' (June 1). The recent developments on the new On Screen Marking (OSM) system has created mistrust among the parents and students. The selection of a vendor with a bad track record needs to be probed further. The legal investigation should cover the methodology adopted by CBSE in conducting multiple rounds of Users Acceptance Testing, action

taken on findings of such tests, details of Penetration testing by a reputed third party vendor, their observations and the compliance on action taken.

**RV Baskaran**  
Pune

## MPC imperatives

Our economy now confronts a policy grey zone. Consumption in critical imports remains inelastic, while tighter monetary conditions could unnecessarily burden investment and domestic demand. The present impasse is proving to be

broadly agnostic to conventional rate action. RBI's key concern through much of 2026 could be preserving macroeconomic stability rather than attempting aggressive policy recalibration. The more probable course is a status quo on rates and a hawkish tone. The RBI may revise inflation forecasts upward, trim growth projections and reinforce its commitment to currency stability and liquidity management.

**R Narayanan**  
Navi Mumbai

## Promising discovery

This refers to the article 'The protein-peptide bonds that heal' (June 1). The research from IIT-Bombay on stapled peptides and their interaction with water molecules marks a genuinely promising advance in cancer drug discovery. What stands out is the shift in focus — from looking only at the drug molecule's shape and binding capability to also examining how it influences surrounding water behaviour.

This entropic insight could meaningfully improve therapeutic efficacy while reducing dosage requirements. That said, the researchers themselves caution that computational findings need extensive experimental and clinical validation before translating into usable medicines. India would do well to invest more consistently in bridging this gap between in-silico research and clinical application.

**M Barathi**  
Bengaluru







QUICKLY.

ConsumerX launches ₹150-cr early-stage AIF



**Bengaluru:** ConsumerX Ventures has launched a SEBI-registered Category II Alternative Investment Fund (AIF) with a target corpus of ₹150 crore to back new-age and digitally native consumer brands. The fund will focus on pre-seed and seed-stage consumer start-ups, supporting founders in the early stages of building product-market fit, brand differentiation and scalable business models. ConsumerX Ventures aims to address what it sees as a funding and support gap for consumer-focused start-ups at the zero-to-one stage. The fund plans to build a concentrated portfolio of 20-25 early-stage consumer companies across categories.

GenXAI Analytics to raise ₹55 cr via NSE Emerge IPO

**Mumbai:** GenXAI Analytics, a technology-driven enterprise performance and analytics solutions provider, plans to raise ₹55 crore through an initial public offering on NSE Emerge platform. The company will issue 47.28 lakh shares in the price band of ₹110-116 a share. The lot size has been fixed at 1,200 shares. The net proceeds from the IPO will be used for capital expenditure for development of new products, working capital requirements and the general corporate purposes. The anchor bidding opens on Thursday while it will open on Friday for other investors. The company has appointed Choice Capital Advisors as the book running lead manager while Bigshare Services will be the Registrar.

IPO market set for revival in June

Akshata Gorde  
Mumbai

After two months of subdued activity, the primary market is set to see a pick-up in June, with a handful of companies lining up public issues even as the larger ones continue to assess market conditions amid geopolitical uncertainty and volatility. The IPO of Hexagon Nutrition, an offer-for-sale (OFS) worth about ₹139 crore, will open for subscription on June 5, while CMR Green Technologies' ₹630-crore OFS is scheduled during June 3-5. In the SME segment, Merritronix, Liotech Industries, Vahh Chemicals and Genxai Analytics are among the companies scheduled to tap the market. The improving June calendar follows a lull that saw only two mainboard IPOs in April and none in May as geopolitical tensions, volatility and valuation concerns prompted several firms to defer their listing plans. "We could see a selective pickup in June, but issuers are likely to remain valuation-sensitive. Companies

CSR mandate to bring life to SSEs

Akshata Gorde  
Mumbai

Social Stock Exchanges (SSE) could see a funding boost of several hundred crores worth institutional capital following the amendment by the Ministry of Corporate Affairs allowing companies to channel up to 10 per cent of their mandatory CSR budgets into listed zero-coupon bonds. The move is expected to solve the twin hurdles that have limited participation for the SSE since its inception: a total lack of institutional scale and an overwhelming compliance burden for corporate boards. Boards can effectively outsource continuous auditing and impact assessment to the exchange framework, while bringing in institutional capital that already faces a statutory mandate to spend. For corporate compliance teams,

MFs' equity investments jump 58% in May

BOTTOM FISHING. Steady inflows from investors help managers deploy funds in falling market

Suresh P Iyengar  
Mumbai

Mutual fund investments in equity markets jumped 58 per cent in May to over ₹48,247 crore against ₹30,594 crore logged in April on the back of healthy inflows as investors used the fall in the markets to pump in more money, according to data sourced from SEBI. Stock indices fell around two per cent last month on the back of a delay in a truce between the warring US and Iran and the damages inflicted to oil refineries in and around West Asia. Moreover, global financial service provider Morgan Stanley has cut the India's weightage in its emerging market index. In its quarterly rebalancing, effective Friday, MSCI has reduced India's weight in the Global Standard index to 12.3 per cent

from 12.4 per cent. The move has triggered a huge sell-off of FPIs in Indian markets.

**CAPITAL FLOWS** The indices provided by New York-based MSCI are keenly eyed by investors across the world because they dictate the flow of capital, especially passive funds that closely track the weights assigned to regions, countries and companies. Shweta Rajani, Head-Mutual Funds, Anand Rath Wealth, said domestic flows are in a very stable zone as investors are increasingly guided by discipline and financial planning rather than market emotion. Though most sectors reported a double-digit earnings growth in Q4, she said margins remained under pressure due to higher commodity and input costs. The pressures are likely to persist into the June quarter as well,



**STRONG UNDERCURRENT.** Despite concerns around corporate earnings, investors are pumping in money with a longer-term perspective, say analysts

keeping margins under watch, she added.

**INFLATION RISK** While commodity inflation and global uncertainties remain risks, the combination of strong economic growth, policy support and an improving earnings cycle provides a positive foundation for both markets and MF investors, she said. Ponmudi R, Founder &

CEO, Enrich Money, said despite concerns around corporate earnings, investors are investing with a longer-term perspective rather than reacting to quarterly earnings volatility. A sharp and sustained rise could impact household savings and disposable income, which may slow incremental investments at the margin. However, the structural story for mutual fund inflows

in India remains strong, he added.

**SIP RESILIENCE** However, SIPs are designed to navigate such phases by averaging costs across market cycles and temporary volatility should not be viewed as a negative for disciplined long-term investors, he said. Hariprasad K, Research Analyst and Founder, Livelong Wealth, said domestic retail participation, led by SIPs, has become a powerful and consistent source of capital that continues to support equities even during periods of volatility. "Rather than sharp market declines, the bigger risk could be prolonged consolidation where earnings gradually catch up to elevated valuations. In such an environment, future returns are likely to be driven more by profit growth than liquidity expansion," he said.

SEBI mulls easing cash-flow rules for road InvITs to boost payouts to unitholders

Our Bureau  
Mumbai



The Securities and Exchange Board of India on Monday proposed allowing road-focused Infrastructure Investment Trusts (InvITs) to add back debt-funded major maintenance expenses while calculating cash available for distribution to investors for ease of doing business. Under the proposal, payments made towards major maintenance of road projects, to the extent funded through external borrowings, can be added back while computing Net Distributable Cash Flow (NDCF).

At present, InvITs are barred from distributing cash flows generated through external debt. In addition, major maintenance expenses are treated as operating costs under accounting rules and are deducted from operating cash flows while calculating NDCF. This reduces distributable cash even when such expenses are financed through borrowings. SEBI

said the proposal has been made after representations from the Bharat InvITs Association and recommendations from the Hybrid Securities Advisory Committee. Major maintenance refers to non-routine expenditure incurred to maintain road assets in line with obligations specified under concession agreements. "Major Maintenance expenses are treated as operating expenses, although the quantum of such expenses over the life of the project is generally significant and such expenses are necessary to maintain the life of road assets and to meet the specifications of the concession agreement," SEBI said in

a draft paper seeking public comments until June 22. The relaxation would apply only to projects classified under the roads and bridges infrastructure sub-sector.

**DISCLOSURE NORMS** SEBI also proposed extensive disclosure requirements, including project-wise maintenance estimates, the impact of maintenance-related borrowing on future growth and distributions, and alternative funding options if debt is unavailable. Statutory auditors will be required to certify that the expenditure qualifies as major maintenance and has been funded through external borrowing.

Despite Q4 loss, IndiGo flies high as brokerages stay bullish

Our Bureau  
Bengaluru

InterGlobe Aviation shares gained on Monday as investors looked past the airline's March quarter loss and focused on strong fare trends, industry-wide capacity constraints and bullish commentary from brokerages. The stock rose as much as 5.2 per cent to ₹4,633.90 on the NSE in early trade from the previous close of ₹4,405 before settling at ₹4,453.30. The parent of IndiGo reported a consolidated loss of ₹2,536.9 crore for the quarter ended March 2026

Nifty slides for fourth day amid geopolitical tension

Anupama Ghosh  
Mumbai

The markets closed lower for the fourth consecutive session on Monday as a brief morning rally evaporated under the weight of renewed West Asia hostilities, surging crude oil prices and persistent foreign selling — a combination that left bulls with little to hold on to through the day. "Recent US strikes and the escalation in cross-border hostilities between Israel and Lebanon have exerted selling pressure on equity markets, reflecting heightened geopolitical uncertainty and a shift towards risk-off sentiment," said Vinod Nair, Head of Research, Geojit Investments. The Sensex closed at 74,267.34, down 508.40 points from its previous close of 74,775.74, having opened the session at 75,203.02. The Nifty 50

settled at 23,382.60, down 165.15 points from Friday's close of 23,547.75, its lowest closing level since May 12. The index opened with a 107-point gap-up but reversed sharply, shedding over 375 points from its intra-day high of 23,733.70.

**SECTORAL SELLOFF** Sectorally, FMCG bore the brunt of the selling, declining 2.25 per cent, with HUL down 1.64 per cent to ₹2,118.10, Tata Consumer falling 1.73 per cent to ₹1,158.00 and ITC also ending among the losers. PSU Banks, Realty, Auto and Financials also ended in the red. IT was the session's standout exception, gaining 2.55 per cent. Broader markets underperformed. The Nifty Midcap 100 fell 1.45 per cent and the Smallcap 100 declined 0.90 per cent. The BSE advance-decline ratio stood at 0.58, reflecting sustained selling beyond the headline index.

against a net profit of ₹3,067.5 crore in the year-ago period. Brokerages, however, said the market was focusing on the longer-term earnings outlook driven by supply shortages in the aviation sector, rising fares and IndiGo's market share gains. Elara Capital said the recent correction in InterGlobe Aviation shares, which have fallen around 25 per cent over the past six months compared with a nearly 10 per cent decline in the Nifty, was driven by temporary operational disruptions and macro concerns such as crude oil prices and INR depreciation. It reiterated a

'Buy' call with a target price of ₹6,020. Motilal Oswal also maintained a 'Buy' rating with a target price of ₹5,600, citing confidence in IndiGo's long-term growth strategy despite near-term headwinds. Global brokerages Jefferies and Goldman Sachs maintained 'Buy' with target prices of ₹5,380 and ₹5,200, respectively. According to Jefferies, IndiGo's near-term outlook remains "clouded" despite the airline maintaining its long-term leadership position in the Indian aviation market. Bank of America reiterated its 'Buy' rating with a target price of ₹5,100.

BROKER'S CALL.

Choice International

**HAPPIEST MINDS (BUY)** Target: ₹560 CMP: ₹378.75 Happiest Minds reported Q4FY26 revenues of ₹604.10 crore, (vs our estimate of ₹645.50 crore), up 2.8 per cent q-o-q and 10.9 per cent y-o-y. In USD terms it reported degrowth of 1.1 per cent q-o-q in revenues at \$65.0 million. For FY26, INR revenues stood at ₹231.50 crore, up 12.3 per cent y-o-y, while the USD revenue stood at \$265.8 million, up 9.1 per cent YoY. EBIT Margin came in at 13.6 per cent for Q4-FY26, declining 90 bps q-o-q (vs CIE estimate of 15.6 per cent). For the full year, EBIT margin stood at 13.6 per cent, up by 70 bps y-o-y. PAT for the quarter came in at ₹6.12 crore, up by 51.8 per cent QoQ and 32.5 per cent y-o-y. For the full year, PAT stood at ₹21.26 crore, up 8 per cent y-o-y. Margin remained stable at 17.5 per cent, aided by improved utilisation and operational efficiency, though continued AI investments may keep near-term profitability range-bound. We believe execution on AI monetisation, platform scaling-up and margin discipline will remain critical for sustaining growth momentum. The management expects margin to improve by about 100 bps over time, targeting an operating margin range of 17.5-18.5 per cent. Accordingly, we expect Revenue/EBIT/PAT to respectively expand at a CAGR of 16.5/21.2/25.6 per cent over FY26-FY29E. While we maintain our 'Buy' rating, we revise our target price to ₹560 (earlier ₹620), based on the FY28E EPS.

Anand Rath

**TBO TEK (BUY)** Target: ₹2,000 CMP: ₹1,233.20 TBO Tek's organic business maintained a steady trajectory in Q4-FY26 with GTV rising by about 16 per cent y-o-y to about ₹9,000 crore. While GTV grew by a strong around 27 per cent y-o-y in January and February, disruption was seen in March, led by West Asia conflicts with Hotels & Ancillaries/Airlines GTV growth of around 20.4/9.4 per cent y-o-y. GTV (including Classic Vacations) grew around 29 per cent y-o-y, led by Hotels GTV/Airline growth of about 39.2/14.6 per cent y-o-y. EBITDA grew 47.14 per cent y-o-y to ₹10,500 crore (in-line with street estimate). EBITDA margin fell around 311 bps y-o-y to about 12.9 per cent (from about 16 per cent in Q4-FY25), due to integration of Classic Vacation, which has lower margin (CV has better EBITDA/GTV conversion (about 2.55 per cent Vs TBO organic 0.9 per cent). Notably, adj EBITDA as percentage of revenue (about 10 per cent) is lower than TBO organic (15.4 per cent). We expect steady performance in H1-FY27e and a strong recovery from H2-FY27e onwards, aided by pent-up demand and platform's diversified architecture. Operating leverage is likely to expand further, as SG&A growth continues to moderate and GP scales. Trimming our earnings estimate by 2.6 per cent for FY27/28e, we maintain Buy rating on the stock with an unrevised TP of ₹2,000, valuing it at around 42x FY28e EPS. **Key risks:** Inability to retain buyers and loss of agents; suppliers changing terms or discontinue supply; and external factors curbing mobility/travel.

businessline is not responsible for the recommendations sourced from third party brokerages. Reports may be sent to: [blmarketwatch@gmail.com](mailto:blmarketwatch@gmail.com)

TODAY'S PICK.

NBCC (India) (₹104.35): BUY

Gurumurthy K  
bl. research bureau

**NBCC (India)** Return -16% ₹ 104 133 121 109 97 85 73 Jun 2, 25 Jun 1, 26

The short-term outlook is bullish for NBCC (India). The stock surged over 4 per cent on Monday when broader markets were beaten down. Monday's rise confirms an inverted head and shoulders pattern on the chart. The neckline support of this pattern is around ₹101. Fresh buyers are likely to come into the market around this support level and limit the downside. Moving average crossovers on the daily chart also strengthen the bullish case. The NBCC (India) share price can rise to ₹118 in the coming weeks. Traders can buy NBCC (India) shares now at ₹104. Accumulate on dips at

₹102. Keep the stop-loss at ₹96. Trail the stop-loss up to ₹107 as soon as the stock goes up to ₹110. Revise the stop-loss higher to ₹111 and ₹114 when the share price touches ₹113 and ₹116 respectively. Exit the long positions at ₹117.

Note: The recommendations are based on technical analysis. There is a risk of loss in trading

Day trading guide

23460

» Nifty 50 Futures

| S1    | S2    | R1    | R2    | COMMENT                                                         |
|-------|-------|-------|-------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|
| 23420 | 23340 | 23560 | 23700 | Go short on a break below 23420.<br>Keep the stop-loss at 23445 |

₹742

» HDFC Bank

| S1  | S2  | R1  | R2  | COMMENT                                                  |
|-----|-----|-----|-----|----------------------------------------------------------|
| 738 | 734 | 748 | 753 | Go short only below 738.<br>Stop-loss can be kept at 739 |

₹1203

» Infosys

| S1   | S2   | R1   | R2   | COMMENT                                                      |
|------|------|------|------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1180 | 1160 | 1220 | 1245 | Take fresh longs only above 1220<br>with a stop-loss at 1215 |

₹279

» ITC

| S1  | S2  | R1  | R2  | COMMENT                                                  |
|-----|-----|-----|-----|----------------------------------------------------------|
| 278 | 272 | 281 | 283 | Go short only below 278.<br>Stop-loss can be kept at 280 |

₹264

» ONGC

| S1  | S2  | R1  | R2  | COMMENT                                               |
|-----|-----|-----|-----|-------------------------------------------------------|
| 261 | 258 | 266 | 270 | Go short now and at 265. Keep the<br>stop-loss at 267 |

₹1322

» Reliance Ind.

| S1   | S2   | R1   | R2   | COMMENT                                                   |
|------|------|------|------|-----------------------------------------------------------|
| 1315 | 1290 | 1340 | 1350 | Go long on a bounce from 1315<br>with a stop-loss at 1310 |

₹955

» SBI

| S1  | S2  | R1  | R2  | COMMENT                                                  |
|-----|-----|-----|-----|----------------------------------------------------------|
| 948 | 945 | 960 | 965 | Go short now and at 958.<br>Stop-loss can be kept at 961 |

₹2299

» TCS

| S1   | S2   | R1   | R2   | COMMENT                                                         |
|------|------|------|------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|
| 2290 | 2260 | 2315 | 2340 | Go long if TCS bounces from 2290.<br>Keep the stop-loss at 2280 |

S1, S2: Support 1 & 2; R1, R2: Resistance 1 & 2.

| Nifty 50 Movers               |          |        |       |       |  | ▼ 165.15 pts. |
|-------------------------------|----------|--------|-------|-------|--|---------------|
|                               | Close(F) | Pts    | PE    | WNN)  |  |               |
| Infosys                       | 1202.50  | 31.82  | 16.55 | 3.93  |  |               |
| TCS                           | 2297.40  | 8.58   | 16.81 | 2.91  |  |               |
| Tech Mahindra                 | 1543.20  | 8.21   | 31.46 | 0.19  |  |               |
| Coal India                    | 472.60   | 7.28   | 9.37  | 1.00  |  |               |
| Hindalco                      | 1141.30  | 4.61   | 19.15 | 1.54  |  |               |
| Tata Steel                    | 210.57   | 4.60   | 24.15 | 1.62  |  |               |
| JSW Steel                     | 1299.40  | 4.38   | 12.46 | 1.14  |  |               |
| HCL Tech                      | 1195.10  | 2.60   | 19.48 | 1.18  |  |               |
| Int'lGlobeAvi                 | 4453.30  | 2.38   | 53.62 | 0.94  |  |               |
| Wipro                         | 206.41   | 1.35   | 16.32 | 0.55  |  |               |
| Sun Pharma                    | 1796.50  | -0.62  | 37.45 | 1.77  |  |               |
| ONGC                          | 264.30   | -0.93  | 6.68  | 0.96  |  |               |
| Cipla                         | 1390.30  | -1.31  | 29.08 | 0.73  |  |               |
| Apollo Hosp                   | 8108.50  | -1.53  | 58.22 | 0.78  |  |               |
| Grassim Ind                   | 3102.60  | -1.64  | 20.50 | 1.10  |  |               |
| SBI Life                      | 1812.50  | -1.72  | 73.59 | 0.76  |  |               |
| Dr Reddy's Lab                | 1290.40  | -1.74  | 25.90 | 0.73  |  |               |
| Adani Enter                   | 2909.40  | -1.75  | 37.77 | 0.78  |  |               |
| Reliance Ind                  | 1320.00  | -1.77  | 18.65 | 0.52  |  |               |
| HDFC Life                     | 586.55   | -1.94  | 66.18 | 8.32  |  |               |
| Bajaj Auto                    | 10376.00 | -2.03  | 27.43 | 1.07  |  |               |
| Eicher Motors                 | 7100.50  | -2.30  | 35.32 | 0.91  |  |               |
| Bharat Elec                   | 496.27   | -2.71  | 49.38 | 1.26  |  |               |
| Jio Financial Services Ltd.   | 234.95   | -2.86  | 95.63 | 0.72  |  |               |
| Bajaj Finserv                 | 1758.90  | -3.11  | 14.31 | 0.95  |  |               |
| Trent Ltd.                    | 4157.30  | -3.23  | 85.86 | 0.86  |  |               |
| Adani Ports                   | 1783.50  | -3.40  | 32.15 | 1.23  |  |               |
| Asian Paints                  | 2632.40  | -3.87  | 64.58 | 1.11  |  |               |
| Eternal Ltd.                  | 248.10   | -3.90  | 65.47 | 1.67  |  |               |
| Tata Motors PV                | 384.90   | -4.11  | 47.84 | 0.75  |  |               |
| Max Healthcare                | 938.45   | -4.33  | 63.31 | 0.65  |  |               |
| PowerGrid Corp                | 286.15   | -4.35  | 16.71 | 1.21  |  |               |
| Nitan                         | 4024.60  | -4.53  | 70.42 | 1.55  |  |               |
| NestleIndia                   | 1391.80  | -4.65  | 76.70 | 0.93  |  |               |
| TataConsumerProduct           | 1143.30  | -4.99  | 73.14 | 0.69  |  |               |
| Maruti Suzuki                 | 12870.00 | -5.18  | 27.73 | 1.59  |  |               |
| HDFC Bank                     | 742.70   | -6.18  | 14.43 | 10.61 |  |               |
| UltraTech Cement              | 11232.00 | -6.46  | 40.42 | 1.24  |  |               |
| Axis Bank                     | 1275.90  | -6.70  | 14.94 | 3.42  |  |               |
| NTPC                          | 378.70   | -8.48  | 13.33 | 1.68  |  |               |
| Shriram Finance Ltd.          | 919.05   | -8.59  | 21.57 | 1.20  |  |               |
| State Bank                    | 954.10   | -8.93  | 10.16 | 3.69  |  |               |
| Kotak Bank                    | 377.40   | -10.92 | 19.46 | 2.29  |  |               |
| Bajaj Finance                 | 889.05   | -11.21 | 28.62 | 2.22  |  |               |
| Bharti Airtel                 | 1810.60  | -12.32 | 32.62 | 5.19  |  |               |
| Hind Unilever                 | 2084.30  | -13.40 | 46.28 | 1.73  |  |               |
| M&M                           | 2970.20  | -14.70 | 19.83 | 2.48  |  |               |
| ITC                           | 279.65   | -15.25 | 16.67 | 2.52  |  |               |
| J&F                           | 4010.80  | -16.83 | 29.11 | 4.39  |  |               |
| ICI Bank                      | 1239.70  | -26.05 | 15.32 | 8.27  |  |               |
| Pts: Impact on index movement |          |        |       |       |  |               |

| Nifty Next 50 Movers          |          |         |        |      |  | ▼ 1,151.80 pts. |
|-------------------------------|----------|---------|--------|------|--|-----------------|
|                               | Close(F) | Pts     | PE     | WNN) |  |                 |
| Ltintindtree                  | 4196.10  | 35.23   | 24.97  | 1.57 |  |                 |
| Zyduslifesciences             | 1091.20  | 9.53    | 21.43  | 1.10 |  |                 |
| AvenueSuper                   | 4071.80  | 7.19    | 89.22  | 2.42 |  |                 |
| Jindal Steel                  | 1209.80  | 2.72    | 36.72  | 1.81 |  |                 |
| Bosch                         | 36705.00 | 1.96    | 39.04  | 1.29 |  |                 |
| Solar Industries              | 18203.00 | -3.03   | 94.85  | 1.79 |  |                 |
| Gall (India)                  | 163.74   | -5.86   | 14.20  | 1.78 |  |                 |
| Tata Power                    | 419.50   | -5.91   | 26.19  | 2.84 |  |                 |
| Tata Capital                  | 300.95   | -6.04   | 26.12  | 0.52 |  |                 |
| Indian Railway Finance Corp   | 96.27    | -7.04   | 17.95  | 0.78 |  |                 |
| Bpd                           | 296.85   | -7.15   | 4.98   | 2.43 |  |                 |
| Mazagon Dock                  | 2423.10  | -7.16   | 35.47  | 0.74 |  |                 |
| Tvs Motor Corp .              | 3344.40  | -7.49   | 49.86  | 3.17 |  |                 |
| Shree Cement                  | 20560.00 | -8.12   | 51.71  | 3.35 |  |                 |
| Hindus Zinc                   | 626.25   | -8.20   | 19.13  | 1.10 |  |                 |
| Varun Beverages.              | 525.95   | -9.66   | 55.38  | 2.90 |  |                 |
| Bajaj Holdings                | 10270.00 | -11.12  | 116.88 | 1.80 |  |                 |
| Indian Oilcorp                | 138.80   | -15.19  | 4.49   | 2.09 |  |                 |
| SBI Ind                       | 515.50   | -15.63  | 48.97  | 2.45 |  |                 |
| Adani Energy Solutions .      | 1496.45  | -16.45  | 75.13  | 2.10 |  |                 |
| Hyundai Motor India .         | 1882.40  | -16.74  | 28.16  | 0.08 |  |                 |
| United Spirits .              | 1248.80  | -17.68  | 48.65  | 1.49 |  |                 |
| Torrent Pharma                | 4350.40  | -17.83  | 68.87  | 1.84 |  |                 |
| Indian Hotels Co .            | 646.75   | -18.59  | 40.97  | 2.29 |  |                 |
| WIPAC                         | 199.10   | -19.10  | 32.55  | 1.50 |  |                 |
| Bank Of Baroda                | 264.35   | -21.73  | 68.11  | 0.98 |  |                 |
| Rural Elec                    | 331.40   | -22.04  | 5.35   | 1.67 |  |                 |
| Punjab Natl Bank              | 103.78   | -22.10  | 6.46   | 1.44 |  |                 |
| Amulbia Cements               | 434.90   | -22.29  | 19.56  | 0.07 |  |                 |
| Pembeta                       | 1457.20  | -22.41  | 60.03  | 1.82 |  |                 |
| Pepsi Consumer                | 1029.00  | -23.05  | 55.46  | 1.66 |  |                 |
| Hindustaneronautics           | 4254.10  | -26.62  | 31.21  | 3.26 |  |                 |
| AdaniGreenenergy              | 1446.90  | -26.97  | 119.94 | 1.96 |  |                 |
| Canara Bank                   | 127.96   | -27.03  | 6.49   | 1.74 |  |                 |
| Union Bank                    | 162.54   | -29.63  | 6.39   | 1.27 |  |                 |
| Muthootfin                    | 3246.40  | -29.21  | 12.29  | 1.41 |  |                 |
| Wardhaya                      | 30.83    | -31.42  | 4.13   | 2.46 |  |                 |
| Tata Motors Cv                | 374.25   | -30.97  | 45.51  | 1.18 |  |                 |
| Siemens                       | 3711.30  | -33.11  | 83.36  | 1.32 |  |                 |
| Abb India                     | 3720.50  | -33.39  | 94.24  | 1.49 |  |                 |
| Macrotech Developers .        | 893.00   | -35.85  | 26.00  | 1.02 |  |                 |
| Siemens Energy India          | 3717.40  | -38.62  | 101.07 | 1.33 |  |                 |
| Sharda                        | 400.03   | -39.02  | 21.14  | 1.14 |  |                 |
| Divis Lab                     | 6553.50  | -40.72  | 67.75  | 3.36 |  |                 |
| Cg Power & Ind Sol            | 494.35   | -44.74  | 117.70 | 2.48 |  |                 |
| Sahamodhersonintertanl        | 141.77   | -49.60  | 36.62  | 2.53 |  |                 |
| Chamundaalamin&Fin            | 1492.90  | -54.16  | 24.30  | 2.58 |  |                 |
| Vedanta                       | 337.15   | -74.11  | 8.31   | 2.31 |  |                 |
| Lumina India                  | 516.46   | -76.66  | 66.67  | 3.08 |  |                 |
| Adani Power.                  | 232.30   | -129.25 | 34.54  | 3.88 |  |                 |
| Pts: Impact on index movement |          |         |        |      |  |                 |



# India seeks a US deal that ensures competitiveness

**STATE INTERESTS.** New Delhi looks for protection against high penal levies under Sec 301

**Amiti Sen**  
New Delhi

India will be able to accept a India-US bilateral trade deal only if the pact gives New Delhi a distinct advantage over its developing country rivals in the American market, sources have said.

“India could accept US tariffs locked-in at mutually agreed levels of around 18 per cent or so, close to what was agreed in the February framework, as long as these insulate against higher levies under the ongoing Section 301 investigations. But no deal will be acceptable which does not give India an advantage over competitors,” a source close to the negotiations told *businessline*.

These intricacies will be discussed in detail in this week’s negotiating round for which a US trade team, headed by chief negotiator Brendan Lynch, has arrived in New Delhi, the source ad-



Union Minister of Commerce & Industry Piyush Goyal ANI

ded. Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal on Monday endorsed US Ambassador to India Sergio Gor’s recent statement that 99 per cent of the India-US trade deal was done.

**IRONING DETAILS**

“Mostly everything is finalised. As you know, US Ambassador Gor said that 99 per cent of the things have been finalised. Discussions are going on about small issues, commas and full stops,” he said talking to the media on Monday. It, however, needs to be seen how the legal changes that have taken

place in the US subsequently get reflected in the final agreement, Goyal said.

Under the February framework, the US offered to lower reciprocal tariffs for India from 25 per cent to 18 per cent — slightly better than rates offered to regional competitors such as Vietnam, Bangladesh, Indonesia, and Malaysia.

It also rolled back the 25 per cent penalties imposed for buying Russian oil. In return, New Delhi agreed to cut tariffs on all industrial and many agricultural products. However, the deal stalled after a US Supreme

Court ruling invalidated reciprocal tariffs. The US then imposed a temporary 10 per cent global tariff expiring July 23, alongside Section 301 investigations that threaten India with steep penalties imposed by the US Trade Representative office.

“If the US agrees to exempt India from additional Section 301 penalties, both now and in the future, it is something that India could work with,” the source said.

But one has to watch how the talks progress. “India’s ultimate objective is to get a trade deal with the US which is better than any of its competitors so that it gains a definite edge in the American market,” the source said.

US Trade Representative Jamieson Greer, too, is expected to visit India. “But that will be after we reach an understanding on the Section 301 investigations and tariffs and we are closer to sealing the deal,” the source said.

# OMCs face a ₹30/litre under recovery on jet fuel

**Our Bureau**  
New Delhi

PSU oil marketing companies (OMCs) are currently incurring an under recovery of ₹30 per litre from the sale of aviation turbine fuel (ATF) to airlines.

“Jet fuel prices are determined based on international prices. There is an under-recovery of around ₹30 per litre on domestic jet fuel but this under-recovery is variable based on international prices,” said Sujata Sharma, Joint Secretary in the Ministry of Petroleum & Natural Gas on Monday.

The conflict in West Asia has squeezed profits of airlines as fuel accounts for their second-largest expense. Analysts expect airlines to face pressure in the short term due to higher fuel costs, longer flight times due to re-routing and a weak rupee against the dollar.

To shield consumers, the government absorbed a part of this burden by reducing excise duties on petrol and diesel. Besides, it has reduced the export levy on jet fuel from ₹16 per litre to ₹9.5.

Meanwhile, ATF prices for

domestic flights were kept unchanged in the June revision, while rates for international flight operations were reduced, providing partial relief to airlines amid rising operational costs.

Accordingly, State-owned OMCs kept prices unchanged for scheduled carriers in their latest monthly revision on June 1. However, prices for jet fuel used in operating international flights were reduced by \$400 per kilolitre. The move forms part of a broader pricing approach aimed at insulating domestic consumers from recent increases in international crude oil prices. Notably, to prevent any substantial increase in expenses, the Central government in April had capped domestic ATF price increases at 25 per cent. Prices for May had also been kept unchanged.



the Delhi and Maharashtra governments reduced value-added tax on ATF.

The central government has also removed airfare caps and kept the 60 per cent free seat allocation rule in abeyance to provide airlines greater pricing flexibility.

Additionally, India’s aviation regulator has temporarily eased pilot flight duty time limitations for long-haul flights in response to global aviation disruptions.

Furthermore, the Airports Economic Regulatory Authority has directed major

airports to reduce landing and parking charges for domestic flights by 25 per cent as part of broader efforts to lower airline operating costs.

Airlines have increasingly been adjusting schedules, reducing frequencies and suspending select routes in an effort to manage costs and preserve profitability.

On its part, Tata Group-promoted Air India announced temporary rationalisation of select domestic and international operations between June and August 2026.

Similarly, industry sources indicated that IndiGo is also undertaking operational adjustments.

As per datasets analysed by *businessline*, international average booking values (ABVs) rose significantly from around ₹22,700 in February to over ₹32,600 in May, while domestic ABVs increased from approximately ₹8,800 to ₹9,400 during the same period.

# OMCs grappling with ₹650 under recovery per domestic LPG cylinder amid geopolitical headwinds

**Rishi Ranjan Kala**  
New Delhi

State-controlled oil marketing companies (OMCs) are facing an under recovery of around ₹650 per 14.2 kg cylinder of liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) for domestic consumers.

Sujata Sharma, Joint Secretary in the Ministry of Petroleum & Natural Gas, said, “There is an under recovery of ₹650 per cylinder on domestic LPG.”

The current demand for the critical cooking fuel, which is used by more than 33 crore households, is around 72,000 tonnes per day (TPD), lower than the normal demand of around 80,000 TPD, as LPG consumption generally declines during summers.

**LPG SUPPLY HIT**

“LPG supply continues to be affected by the prevailing geopolitical situation. Supply of LPG to domestic households has been prioritised. No dry-outs have been reported at LPG distributorships. Online LPG cylinder bookings increased to about 99 per cent on an industry basis on Sunday,” she added.

There is also a positive development on migrating consumers from LPG to domestic piped natural gas (D-PNG). Since March 2026, about 8.56 lakh PNG connections have been gasified and infrastructure has been created for additional 2.96 lakh connections, taking the total to 11.52 lakh connections.



**SEASONAL DIP.** The current demand for the critical cooking fuel is around 72,000 tonnes per day, as LPG consumption generally declines during summer REUTERS

Besides, around 8.78 lakh customers have been registered for new connections. As of May 2026, more than 77,800 PNG consumers have surrendered their LPG connections.

The prices of 5 kg FTL (free trade LPG) cylinders have been hiked by ₹11 to ₹821.50 per cylinder in Delhi, effective June 1, 2026.

The government has set up a three-member committee of executive directors of the three PSU OMCs in consultation with States and industry bodies to finalise the plan for the sale of commercial LPG in the States/UTs.

During May 2026, a total of 2,09,353 tonnes of commercial LPG was sold, Sharma noted.

Similarly, about 8,382 tonnes of auto LPG was sold by PSU OMCs in May 2026, which is a 170 per cent increase over February 2026.

**RECORD OUTPUT**

India’s production of LPG hit a record 52,000 TPD last week from roughly 46,000 TPD at the beginning of May 2026 as refineries such as Vadinar resumed operations following a maintenance shut down in April 2026.

India’s average LPG production had declined to around 46,000-47,000 TPD in the first week of April 2026 compared to 50,000 TPD achieved in the last week of March.

## Commercial LPG price hiked by ₹42, 5-kg LPG up by ₹11

**Press Trust of India**  
New Delhi

Prices of commercial LPG — the one used in hotels and restaurants — as well as 5-kg market-priced LPG cylinders were on Monday hiked in line with global benchmarks, but rates of cooking gas used in household kitchens were kept unchanged.

The price of commercial LPG was hiked by ₹42 to ₹3,113.50 per 19-kg cylinder from ₹3,071.50 in Delhi, industry sources said.

The latest increase follows a sharp ₹993 hike implemented on May 1, taking commercial LPG prices to their highest-ever levels.

Prices of 5-kg free-trade LPG (FTL) cylinders were also increased by ₹11 to ₹821.50 per cylinder. Household consumers were spared any increase, with the price of the 14.2-kg domestic LPG cylinder remaining unchanged at ₹913 since early March, when rates were increased by ₹60 per bottle.

The revisions are part of the monthly price review undertaken by State-owned oil marketing companies.

Prices vary from State to State depending on the incidence of local taxes, such as VAT. While commercial LPG prices have climbed to record highs, household cooking gas rates have remained unchanged despite a sharp rise in import costs, underscoring the government’s efforts to shield consumers from global energy volatility, government sources said.

The cost of supplying a 14.2-kg domestic LPG cylinder has risen by about two-fifths in recent months, driven largely by a surge in international benchmark prices. Yet retail prices for households have remained frozen.

## Invesco Mutual Fund

**Invesco Asset Management (India) Pvt. Ltd.**  
(CIN: U67190MH2005PTC153471), 2101-A, 21<sup>st</sup> Floor, A Wing, Marathon Futorex, N. M. Joshi Marg, Lower Parel, Mumbai - 400 013

Telephone: +91 22 6731 0000, Email: [mfservices@invescoindia.com](mailto:mfservices@invescoindia.com); [www.invescomutualfund.com](http://www.invescomutualfund.com)

### NOTICE

NOTICE is hereby given that Invesco Trustee Pvt. Ltd., **(the Trustee to Invesco Mutual Fund)** has approved the declaration of Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal **(‘IDCW’)** in the following scheme, the particulars of which are as under:

| Name of the Scheme                                                                 | Plan(s) / Option(s)        | Amount of IDCW* (Rs. per unit) | NAV as on May 29, 2026 (Rs. per unit) | Record Date* |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------|--------------------------------|---------------------------------------|--------------|
| Invesco India Balanced Advantage Fund, an open ended dynamic asset allocation fund | Regular Plan - IDCW Option | 0.14                           | 17.22                                 | June 4, 2026 |
|                                                                                    | Direct Plan - IDCW Option  |                                | 21.60                                 |              |

\*Distribution of the above IDCW is subject to the availability of distributable surplus and may be lower to the extent of distributable surplus available on the record date. IDCW payable to the unit holder(s) will be lower to the extent of tax deducted at source, at applicable rates.

\*or immediately following Business Day if that day is not a Business Day.

Face Value per unit is Rs. 10/-.

**Pursuant to payment of IDCW, the NAV of the IDCW Options of the scheme would fall to the extent of payout and statutory levy, if any.**

Unit holders of the aforesaid scheme, whose names appear in the records of the Registrar, KFin Technologies Limited, as at the close of business hours on **Thursday, June 4, 2026** or immediately following Business Day if that day is not a Business Day (including valid purchase/switch-in application received till 3.00 p.m. on the record date, subject to the entire amount of subscription/ purchase as per the application / switch-in request is available for utilization by the scheme before the cut-off time on the record date) will be entitled to receive the IDCW.

Unit holders holding units in dematerialized (electronic) form whose names appear in the statement of beneficial owners maintained by the Depositories under the aforesaid scheme as at the close of business hours on **Thursday, June 4, 2026** will be entitled to receive the IDCW.

With regard to Unit holders under IDCW options of the aforesaid scheme, who have opted for IDCW Reinvestment facility, the IDCW due will be reinvested by allotting units for the IDCW amount (net of applicable taxes and stamp duty) (on the next Business Day after the Record Date) at a price based on the prevailing ex-IDCW NAV per unit on the record date.

**For Invesco Asset Management (India) Pvt. Ltd. (Investment Manager for Invesco Mutual Fund)**

**Sd/-**

**Saurabh Nanavati**  
**Managing Director & Chief Executive Officer**

**Date: June 1, 2026**

**Mutual Fund investments are subject to market risks, read all scheme related documents carefully.**

## GHCL Limited

**Registered Office :** GHCL House, Opp. Punjabi Hall, Navrangpura, Ahmedabad-380009 (Gujarat).  
**Phone :** 079-26427818, 26427519. (CIN : L24100GJ1983PLC006513)  
**Corporate Office :** GHCL House, B-38, Institutional Area, Noida, Sector-1, (UP) Ph. 0120-4939900  
**Email :** [ghclinfo@ghcl.co.in](mailto:ghclinfo@ghcl.co.in); [secretarial@ghcl.co.in](mailto:secretarial@ghcl.co.in); **Website :** [www.ghcl.co.in](http://www.ghcl.co.in)

### NOTICE OF 43RD ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING AND REMOTE E-VOTING INFORMATION

In continuation of our previous advertisement published on May 22, 2026, we hereby issue a NOTICE to inform you that 43rd Annual General Meeting of the members of GHCL Limited (CIN : L24100GJ1983PLC006513), will be held on Thursday, June 25, 2026 (गुरुवार, ज्येष्ठ शुक्ल पक्ष - एकादशी, विक्रम संवत् २०८३) at 10.00 a.m. through Video Conferencing (VC) or Other Audio Visual Means (OAVM).

|                                   |                                              |
|-----------------------------------|----------------------------------------------|
| <b>EVSN</b>                       | <b>260529001</b>                             |
| <b>Remote e-voting Start date</b> | <b>Sunday, June 21, 2026 at 9:00 A.M.</b>    |
| <b>Remote e-voting End date</b>   | <b>Wednesday, June 24, 2026 at 5:00 P.M.</b> |

In accordance with the circulars issued by the Ministry of Corporate Affairs (MCA) and the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI), companies are permitted to conduct AGMs through VC / OAVM without the physical presence of members at a common venue. Therefore, our Company has opted to hold the AGM via VC to discuss and transact the business outlined in the Notice of AGM dated May 5, 2026.

In compliance with the circulars, we have electronically sent the notice of the 43rd AGM and the Integrated Annual Report of our Company for the financial year 2025-26 to all members whose email addresses are registered with the Company or Depository Participants. The dispatch of the Integrated Annual Report including AGM notice via email was completed on June 1, 2026 (Monday).

Further, in accordance with Regulation 36(1)(b) of the SEBI Listing Regulations, 2015, on June 1, 2026, a letter providing a weblink including exact path and QR code for accessing the Notice of the AGM and Integrated Annual Report for the financial year 2025-26 has been sent to those shareholders whose email ids are not registered with Company / RTA/ Depository through courier / post.

These documents are also accessible on our company’s website ([www.ghcl.co.in](http://www.ghcl.co.in)), as well as on the websites of BSE Limited ([www.bseindia.com](http://www.bseindia.com)), National Stock Exchange of India Limited ([www.nseindia.com](http://www.nseindia.com)) and CDSL ([www.evotingindia.com](http://www.evotingindia.com)).

As per the cut-off date, which is June 18, 2026 (Thursday), the voting rights of members will be determined based on their shares of the paid-up equity share capital of the Company. To facilitate the voting process, Central Depository Services Limited (CDSL) will provide the option for members to cast their votes through an electronic voting system, known as “remote e-voting.” The Notice of the AGM includes information on the process and procedure for remote e-voting, as well as instructions for participating in the AGM through video conference.

The remote e-voting period for the 43rd AGM will commence at 9.00 am (IST) on Sunday, June 21, 2026 and ends at 5:00 p.m. (IST) on Wednesday, June 24, 2026. During this period, members of the Company may electronically cast their votes on the agenda items specified in the Notice. The e-voting module will be disabled after the voting period ends, and no further changes to the cast votes will be allowed.

Additionally, members attending the meeting will have the option to vote through the electronic voting system during the AGM. Those members who have already casted their votes through remote e-voting will be able to attend the meeting but will not be eligible to vote again. Detailed instructions for members regarding remote e-voting were provided in the AGM Notice and the newspaper advertisement published on May 22, 2026.

If you have any queries or issues regarding e-voting, we have provided resources to assist you. You can refer to the Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs) and e-voting manual available at [www.evotingindia.com](http://www.evotingindia.com) under the help section. Additionally, you can reach out for support by sending an email to [helpdesk.evoting@cdslindia.com](mailto:helpdesk.evoting@cdslindia.com) or by calling 1800-21-09911. Alternatively, you may contact the concerned employees of CDSL at 022-62343626 / 022-62343624 / 022-62343611 between 10:00 a.m. to 6:30 p.m. from Monday to Friday.

For any grievances related to electronic voting, you can contact to Mr. Prashant Kirtikar, / MUFG Intime India Pvt. Ltd. (Formerly Link Intime India Private Limited), C-101, 247 Park, L.B.S. Marg, Vikhroli (West), Mumbai-400083; Telephone number : +91-8108116767 and Email : [mt.helpdesk@in.mpmg.mufg.com](mailto:mt.helpdesk@in.mpmg.mufg.com)

We kindly request that you send your queries at least seven days in advance of the meeting to ensure that the information can be made available and addressed during the meeting.

Your engagement and participation are highly valued, and we are here to provide assistance and support throughout the e-voting process.

| Details of the documents          | Web-link (including the exact path)                                                                                                                                                           | QR Code                                                                               |
|-----------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Integrated Annual Report :</b> | <a href="https://ghcl.co.in/wp-content/uploads/2026/06/43rd-Integrated-Annual-Report-2025-26.pdf">https://ghcl.co.in/wp-content/uploads/2026/06/43rd-Integrated-Annual-Report-2025-26.pdf</a> |  |

Place : Noida  
Date : June 01, 2026

For GHCL Limited  
**Bhuweshwar Mishra**  
VP - Sustainability & Company Secretary



QUICKLY.

IRDA slaps ₹1 cr fine on Nissan Renault Financial



**Hyderabad:** The Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI) has imposed ₹1 crore penalty on Nissan Renault Financial Services India, a corporate agent, for violation of guidelines pertaining to motor insurance service, among others violations. The insurance regulatory authority also directed the company to place the order before the Board of the corporate agent in the upcoming board meeting and provide a copy of the minutes of the discussion to the regulator. “The corporate agent should submit an action taken report to the Authority within 90 days from the date of this order,” IRDAI said on Monday. **OUR BUREAU**

# UPI clocks record volume and value in May as PhonePe, GPay dominate

**SEASONAL JUMP.** Average daily transaction volumes reach 748 million with average value of ₹96,465 crore

**Our Bureau**  
Bengaluru

Unified Payments Interface (UPI) transactions touched a record high in May, with transaction value rising 3 per cent month-on-month to ₹29.90 trillion from ₹29.03 trillion in April, according to data released by the National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI). Transaction volume rose 4 per cent month-on-month to 23.20 billion in May from 22.35 billion in April. Average daily transaction volume stood at 748 million, while the average daily transaction value was ₹96,465 crore. Industry executives attributed the growth to higher consumer spending during the summer travel season,

the IPL 2026 tournament and seasonal consumption trends. The resulting 23.20 billion transactions worth ₹29.90 lakh crore marked a healthy month-on-month recovery and extended UPI's steady growth trajectory. **DOMINANT FORCES** The UPI ecosystem continues to be dominated by PhonePe and Google Pay. In April, PhonePe processed 10.33 billion transactions, while Google Pay handled 7.36 billion transactions. As of April, 713 banks were live on the UPI platform. PhonePe accounted for 46.2 per cent of UPI transaction volume in April and 49.3 per cent of transaction value. Google Pay retained the second spot with a 33 per cent market share by volume, while Paytm re-



**ON THE RISE.** The 23.20 billion transactions in May worth ₹29.90 lakh crore marked a healthy month-on-month recovery and extended UPI's steady growth **ALLEN EGENUSE J**

mained the third-largest player with about 8 per cent. NPCI is yet to release the market-share data for May. UPI is currently live in seven countries, including the UAE, Singapore, Bhutan, Nepal and Mauritius.

Anand Kumar Bajaj, Founder, MD and CEO of PayNearby, said developments in cross-border acceptance, merchant infrastructure, security and credit integration are deepening trust in the UPI ecosystem.

# Bank savings deposits fall sharply, term deposits increase

**Our Bureau**  
Mumbai

The composition of scheduled commercial banks' (SCBs) aggregate deposits has undergone a structural shift over the last five years, characterised by a decline in the share of savings deposits and increase in term deposits, according to RBI data. This comes in the backdrop of savings deposit rates going down from 2.70/3.00 per cent in March 2022 to 2.50 per cent in March 2026 even as term deposit rates of more than one-year tenor rose from 5.00/5.60 per cent to 6.00/6.60 per cent in the said period. The proportion of SCBs' savings deposits declined from 34.6 per cent in March 2022 to 28.7 per cent in

March 2026. In tandem, the proportion of term deposits, which usually attracts higher interest rates, ascended from 55.2 per cent to 61.6 per cent during the said period. The proportion of term deposits in SCBs' overall deposits increased to 61.6 per cent as at March-end 2026 from 61.1 per cent as at March-end 2025. **GROWTH MOMENTUM** Simultaneously, the proportion of savings deposits and current account (CA) deposits in banks' overall deposits declined to 28.7 per cent (from 29.1 per cent as at March-end 2025) and 9.7 per cent (9.8 per cent), respectively. During the FY26, public sector banks acted as the predominant driver of deposits accretion, accounting



**LUCRATIVE INTEREST.** The proportion of term deposits in SCBs' overall deposits increased to 61.6% at March-end 2026 from 61.1% at March-end 2025

for 50.8 per cent of the incremental deposits, followed by private sector banks with a contribution of 38.6 per cent, per RBI's Annual Basic Statistical Return (BSR) on Deposits with SCBs. Growth (year-on-year/y-o-y) of deposits with SCBs

accelerated during FY26 and stood at 11.5 per cent as on end-March 2026 as compared to 10.6 per cent a year ago. **HOUSEHOLD SECTOR** The RBI noted that although the share of deposits of the

household sector moderated in the recent period, it remained the primary contributor, accounting for 59.3 per cent of total deposits as on end-March 2026. On the other hand, the share of deposits held by the non-financial sector increased to 18.5 per cent in March 2026 from 17.7 per cent in March 2025, while share for financial corporations too moved in the same direction from 6.8 per cent to 7.8 per cent in the same period. The share of term deposits with an original maturity of one to three years rose steadily to 69.8 per cent in March 2026 from 50.4 per cent in March 2022, whereas the proportion of term deposits of maturity up to one year came down to 8.8 per cent from 16.7 per cent during the same period. The share of term deposits with an original maturity of one to three years rose steadily to 69.8 per cent in March 2026 from 50.4 per cent in March 2022, whereas the proportion of term deposits of maturity up to one year came down to 8.8 per cent from 16.7 per cent during the same period.

# Persistent Systems ties up with Estonian firm to expand presence in East Europe

**Our Bureau**  
Bengaluru

Persistent Systems has signed an agreement to expand its Eastern European presence through the integration of a specialised team of more than 90 professionals from Concise, a Tallinn-headquartered software engineering and IT consulting company. Subject to closing conditions, the transaction will strengthen Persistent's European nearshore delivery network and enhance its

ability to help enterprises evolve large-scale digital infrastructure and globally integrated operations. Upon completion, the transaction will expand Persistent's Eastern European footprint, establish strategic delivery centres in Tallinn and Tartu, Estonia. Estonia's advanced digital ecosystem and deep technology talent base will provide a strong foundation for supporting AI-led transformation requiring governance alignment and stronger regional engagement. The expansion also aims

to strengthen Persistent's expertise with a strategic customer in the enterprise mobility segment in the region. The team brings experience supporting large-scale digital environments across mobility, logistics, smart infrastructure and payments. Markko Abel, Owner, Concise, said, “Our teams have built strong capabilities in developing and scaling platforms that support real-time, high-volume environments. Becoming part of Persistent allows us to extend this work within a larger global ecosystem.”

addition to our global delivery network and enhance our ability to support clients seeking faster execution, stronger regional engagement and largescale modernisation programs across Europe and other strategic global markets.” Markko Abel, Owner, Concise, said, “Our teams have built strong capabilities in developing and scaling platforms that support real-time, high-volume environments. Becoming part of Persistent allows us to extend this work within a larger global ecosystem.”

# Gujarat Energy's PNG demand jumps 20x with the reopening of Morbi ceramic hub

**Avinash Nair**  
Ahmedabad

India's largest city gas distribution company, Gujarat Energy Ltd (GEL) has reported a dramatic revival in gas demand from India's biggest ceramic cluster at Morbi in Gujarat with consumption jumping more than 20-fold in less than three months between March-May 2026, marking a sharp turnaround for a market where the company had been steadily losing volumes to alternative fuels. The company — formerly known as Gujarat Gas Ltd — on Monday said the gas consumption from ceramic units in Morbi surged from 0.36 million metric standard cubic metres per day (mmscmd) in March to 8 mmscmd by late May. The number of gas-consuming units in Morbi also increased eight-fold, rising from 83 to 710 during this three-month period. “Morbi ceramic cluster remains our largest partner in the PNG industrial segment.



**BACK FROM THE BRINK.** The sharp swing in volumes comes against the backdrop of disruption earlier this year **M A SRIRAM**

Our successful supply strategy has provided significant support to the ceramic industry in Morbi during the crisis period of March to May 2026. The number of units off taking gas increased from 83 units with gas consumption of 0.36 MMSCMD in March 2026 to 710 units with gas consumption reaching approximately 8 MMSCMD by the last week of May 2026.” Avantika Singh Aulakh, Managing Director of the company, told investors. The sharp swing in volumes comes against the backdrop of extreme disruption

earlier this year, when over 700 ceramic units — accounting for nearly 80 per cent of India's ₹65,000 crore ceramic tile production base in Morbi — were forced to shut operations for close to a month after natural gas supplies ran dry following West Asia-related supply constraints. **DIFFERENT CONTRACTS** With fuel unavailable, the cluster's gas consumption collapsed to just 0.36 MMSCMD by March-end. Industry sources said that the ceramic units, have increasingly shifted to shorter,

month-long contracts with GEL for PNG rather than long-term commitments, reflecting uncertainty around fuel availability. The price of PNG supplied to Morbi industrial users has also risen from ₹41.6 per scm (standard cubic metres) earlier to ₹75 per scm currently, reflecting tighter supply conditions and higher input costs. In comparison, GEL is supplying PNG at ₹68 per scm to non-Morbi industrial customers. **SHARP TURNAROUND** The rebound nevertheless marks a significant relief for GEL, which had been facing pressure to defend market share in a region that accounts for a substantial portion of industrial gas consumption. The resurgence in Morbi comes amid broader efforts by GEL to deepen natural gas adoption across Gujarat. Between March and May, the company converted 86 residential societies, comprising around 13,000 households, into fully PNG-connected.

# India-Oman FTA exempts duty for 99% Indian exports

**Our Bureau**  
New Delhi

The India-Oman comprehensive economic partnership agreement (CEPA) came into force on Monday providing duty-free access to 98 per cent of Indian tariff lines, covering about 99 per cent of the country's exports including textiles, gems & jewellery, engineering goods, agriculture and marine products and pharmaceuticals. Oman gained from tariff elimination or reduction on 78 per cent of its tariff lines and is set to benefit in sectors such as energy, fertilisers, and industrial raw materials. Indian consumers are also set to get cheaper Omani dates as imports of the fruit will enjoy duty-based concessions



Union Minister Piyush Goyal with Ambassador of Oman to India Issa Saleh Abdullah Alshibani on Monday **ANI**

## BIG EXEMPTION

“With 99.38 per cent of India's exports receiving duty-free access, the agreement unlocks new opportunities for our exporters and professionals to gain opportunities,” Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal said on Monday. Indian exports to Oman totaled about \$4 billion in fiscal 2026, led by refined pet-

roleum products such as petrol (\$781 million) and naphtha (\$746 million), per a report by research body Global Trade Research Initiative (GTRI). “Although more than 80 per cent of Indian exports already entered Oman at relatively low average tariffs of around 5 per cent, duties on certain products reached as high as 100 per cent. Bilateral trade between India and Oman reached \$11.18 billion in FY26, up from \$10.61 billion the previous fiscal. The agreement is expected to significantly boost MSMEs, manufacturing and employment in labour-intensive sectors such as gems and jewellery, textiles, leather, footwear, marine products and engineering goods.

**TATA POWER**  
(Corporate Contracts Department, 5<sup>th</sup> Floor Station B)  
Tata Power, Trombay Thermal Power Station Chembur-Mahul, Mumbai 400074, Maharashtra, India.  
(Board Line: 022-87175323, Mobile: 7208017950) CIN: L2820MH1913PLC000567

**NOTICE INVITING TENDER**

The Tata Power Company Limited invites tender from eligible vendors for the following package.

1. **AMC for Jetty O&M Services at Tata Power Tankage Division for period of 3 years at Trombay Thermal Power Plant, Mumbai.**
2. **Supply of ARC valve for unit 7 HPBFP system for Unit 7 overhaul for upcoming Unit 7 outage in Jan'27 FY 27**

Interested and eligible bidders to submit Tender Fee and Authorization Letter before **10<sup>th</sup> June 2026**. For detailed NIT, please visit Tender section on website <https://www.tatapower.com>. Also, all future corrigendum's if any, to the said tender will be published on Tender section of above website  
(Tata Power → Business Associates → Tender Documents) only.

**PITTI PITTI ENGINEERING LIMITED**  
Regd. Office: 6-3-648/401, 4<sup>th</sup> Floor, Padmaja Landmark, Somajiguda, Hyderabad - 500 082, Telangana, India.  
Ph: 040-23312774, Email : shares@pitti.in, Website: www.pitti.in  
CIN : L29253TG1983PLC004141

**SPECIAL WINDOW FOR RE-LODGE OF TRANSFER REQUEST OF PHYSICAL SHARES**

Pursuant to SEBI Circular HO/38/13/11(2)/2026-MIRSD-POD/I/3750/2026 dated 30th January, 2026, all shareholders of the Company are hereby informed that a special Window is reopened for a period of one year from 5<sup>th</sup> February, 2026 to 4<sup>th</sup> February, 2027 for re-lodgement of transfer deeds of physical shares which were lodged prior to 1<sup>st</sup> April 2019 and which were rejected, returned or not attended to due to deficiency in the documents/process or otherwise.  
All such transfers shall be credited to the transferee only in demat mode and shall be under lock-in for a period of one year from the date of transfer. Kindly refer to the matrix below with regard to applicability of the lodgement.

| Execution Date of Transfer Deed   | Lodged for Transfer before 1 <sup>st</sup> April 2019 ? | Original Security Certificate Available? | Eligible to Lodge in Current Window? |
|-----------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|
| Before 1 <sup>st</sup> April 2019 | No (Is it fresh lodgement)                              | Yes                                      | ✓                                    |
| Before 1 <sup>st</sup> April 2019 | Yes (It was rejected / returned earlier)                | Yes                                      | ✓                                    |
| Before 1 <sup>st</sup> April 2019 | Yes                                                     | No                                       | ✗                                    |
| Before 1 <sup>st</sup> April 2019 | No                                                      | No                                       | ✗                                    |

The shareholders / investors are hereby informed that they may re-lodge the transfer requests along with the requisite documents with the Company's Registrar and Share Transfer Agents: MUGF Intime India Private Limited, Unit: Pitti Engineering Limited, C 101, Embassy 247, L.B.S. Marg, Vikhroli (West), Mumbai - 400083. Tel. No. +91 810 811 6767, Email: investor.helpdesk@in.mnps.mugf.com

Securities already transferred to IEPF account or cases involving disputes between transferor and transferee or non-availability of share certificates shall not be considered.

**For Pitti Engineering Limited**  
Sd/-  
**Mary Monica Braganza**  
Company Secretary & Chief Compliance Officer  
FCS: 5532

Place: Hyderabad  
Date : 1<sup>st</sup> June 2026

**MOIL LIMITED**  
(A GOVERNMENT OF INDIA ENTERPRISE)  
Registered & Corporate Office:  
MOIL Bhavan, 1-A, Katol Road, Nagpur - 440013, Maharashtra  
CIN: L99999MH1962C01012398

**GLOBAL TENDER NOTICE**

Tenders in three parts are invited from bonafide and experienced contractors for the following works.

| Sr. No. | Description & Place of Work                                                                                                                                                                                                                        | Completion Period | EMD Amount (INR in Crore) | Estimated Cost (Approx.) (INR in Crores) |
|---------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------|---------------------------|------------------------------------------|
| 1       | Design, Construction, Furnishing & Equipping of Third Vertical Shaft on TURNKEY BASIS at Chikla Mine of MOIL Ltd. Tumsar Tehsil, Bhandara District, Maharashtra, India. Pin Code - 441907<br>Tender No: MOIL/MOIL LIMITED/ Project/2/2026-27/ET/22 | 48 Months         | 0.50                      | 208.17 plus GST as applicable            |

For details of Global Tender Document and schedule of e-tender, visit e-tender website <https://www.mstcecommerce.com/eproc/> (for e-bid) & MOIL website <https://moil.nic.in> an Indian Government's Central Public Procurement (CPP) Portal (<https://eprocure.gov.in>).  
**Corrigendum**, if any, shall be uploaded on the above-mentioned websites and shall not be published in the Newspapers.

**Executive Director (P&D), MOIL Limited**

◆ हर एक काम देश के नाम ◆  
**◆ MOIL - Adding Strength to Steel ◆**

**SOBHA LIMITED**  
CIN : L45201KA1995PLC018475  
Regd. Office: 'SOBHA' Sarjapur - Marathahalli Outer Ring Road (ORR), Devarabisanahalli, Bellandur Post, Bangalore - 560 103  
Ph: +91-80-49320000, Email: investors@sobha.com, Website: www.sobha.com

**NOTICE TO THE SHAREHOLDERS**  
[For the attention of Equity Shareholders of the Company]  
(Transfer of Equity Shares to Investor Education and Protection Fund)

This Notice is given pursuant to the provisions of Section 124(6) of the Companies Act 2013 read with Investor Education and Protection Fund Authority (Accounting Audit, Transfer and Refund) Rules, 2016 and subsequent amendments thereto.

The shareholders may note that the dividend declared by the Company for the Financial Year 2018-19, which remained unclaimed for seven years, is due for transfer to the Investor Education and Protection Fund (IEPF) after the closure of the 7th year, i.e. on September 15, 2026. The equity shares held by those shareholders who have not claimed the dividend for the consecutive seven years starting from Financial Year 2018-19 are due for transfer to IEPF and will be transferred to IEPF subsequently on transfer of the dividend amount as per the procedure set out in the rules.

In compliance with the provisions of the rules, the Company has sent/is sending individual notices at the latest available addresses of the respective shareholders whose dividends are lying unclaimed for the last 7 consecutive years, advising them to claim the dividends expeditiously. Further the Company has uploaded the full details of shareholders including their folio number or DP4D-Client ID and shares due for transfer to IEPF on its website [www.sobha.com](http://www.sobha.com). Shareholders are requested to refer to the website to verify the details of unclaimed dividend and shares liable to be transferred to IEPF.

In case the Company does not receive any communication from the concerned shareholders by September 15, 2026, the Company shall with a view to adhering with the requirements set out in the Rules, transfer the shares of concerned shareholders to IEPF by due date i.e. October 15, 2026. Please note that no claim shall lie against the Company in respect of the unclaimed dividend amount and shares transferred to IEPF pursuant to the said rules.

Shareholders may note that both unclaimed/ unpaid dividend(s) and the corresponding shares transferred to IEPF including all benefits accruing thereon, if any, can be claimed back by the shareholders from IEPF Authority after following the procedure prescribed in the aforesaid rules. Concerned shareholders, holding shares

In Physical form and whose shares are liable to be transferred to IEPF, may note that the Company would be issuing duplicate share certificates in lieu of the original share certificate(s) held by them for the purpose of transfer of shares to IEPF as per the Rules and upon issue of such duplicate share certificates, the Company shall inform the depository by way of corporate action to convert the duplicate share certificate into DEMAT form and transfer in favour of IEPF. The original share certificate(s) which stand registered in the name of the original shareholder will stand automatically cancelled and be deemed non-negotiable. Concerned shareholders holding shares in dematerialized form may note that the Company shall inform the depository by way of corporate action for transfer of shares in favour of the DEMAT account of the IEPF.

The shareholder may further note that the details uploaded by the Company on its website should be regarded and shall be deemed adequate notice in respect of the issue of duplicate share certificate(s) by the Company for the purpose of transfer of shares to IEPF pursuant to the Rules.

In case the concerned shareholder have any query on the subject matter and the Rules, they may either contact the Secretarial Department of the Company at 'SOBHA' Sarjapur - Marathahalli Outer Ring Road (ORR), Devarabisanahalli, Bellandur Post, Bangalore - 560103, Tel: 080-49320000, e-mail ID: investors@sobha.com or Company's Registrar and Transfer Agent, MUGF Intime India Private Limited, C-101, Embassy 247, L.B.S. Marg/Vikhroli (West), Mumbai - 400083, Tel No. 022-25946970, e-mail ID: investor.helpdesk@in.mnps.mugf.com

For Sobha Limited  
On Behalf of the Board of Directors

Sd/-  
Bijan Kumar Dash  
Company Secretary & Compliance Officer

Date : June 01, 2026  
Place : Bangalore



QUICKLY.

Avaada Group secures ₹9,000 cr for RE projects

**New Delhi:** The Avaada Group on Monday said it has secured \$950 million (around ₹9,000 crore) in finance from a consortium of banks. Avaada Group, a diversified clean energy conglomerate, announced the successful financial closure of its firm and dispatchable renewable energy (FDRE) project in Bikaner, Rajasthan, marking India's largest financing transaction in the FDRE segment, a company statement said. **PTI**

Fino, Ezee.ai partner to strengthen lending

**New Delhi:** Fino Payments Bank announced a partnership with fintech platform Ezee.ai to build a lending ecosystem and strengthen its capabilities as it prepares for its transition into a Small Finance Bank. Ezee.ai will deploy its AI-enabled Loan Origination System, Business Rules Engine, and Collections Management Platform to support the bank's lending operations, Fino Payments Bank said in a regulatory filing. **PTI**

# IT services firms raise R&D spending in FY26, but investment levels modest

**GROWTH DISCIPLINE.** They are seeking a balance between profitability and future-ready tech investments

**Sanjana B**  
Bengaluru

Even as Indian IT services firms increase spending on research and development, their investments remain a fraction of those made by their global technology peers, raising questions about whether the industry's innovation budgets are keeping pace with the demands of the AI era.

**INVESTMENT GROWTH**  
Among Indian IT services companies, on a standalone basis, Infosys increased its research and development (R&D) expenditure to ₹1,093 crore in FY26, up from ₹850 crore in FY25. R&D spending accounted for 0.73 per cent of total revenue in FY26, compared with 0.62 per cent a year earlier, as per the company's annual report. Tata Consultancy Services



**WARNING SIGNS.** Experts warn that underinvestment in innovation could weaken long-term competitiveness and growth

reported standalone R&D and innovation expenditure of ₹2,814 crore in FY26, representing 1.3 per cent of total turnover, compared with ₹2,546 crore, which was 1.2 per cent of turnover in FY25. On a consolidated basis, the company spent ₹2,900 crore on R&D in FY26, equivalent to 1.1 per cent of turnover, up from ₹2,630 crore — 1 per cent of turnover in FY25. TCS's India research centres function in Pune,

Chennai, Bengaluru, Delhi-NCR, Hyderabad, Kolkata and Mumbai. The company's Pace Port and Pace Studio innovation hubs operate in Amsterdam, Toronto, Pittsburgh, Tokyo, New York, London, Paris, Singapore, Sao Paulo, Riyadh, Letterkenny, Sydney, Stockholm and Manila. "Margins saw support from greater productivity and realisation, pyramid restructuring and favourable currency trends, which enabled

investments in talent, learning and development, research and innovation, infrastructure, capability building and business growth. Despite these investments, operating margins expanded by 70 basis points," the company said in its annual report. LTM incurred R&D expenditure of ₹122.1 crore in FY26, compared with ₹90.7 crore in FY25, as per the company's annual report.

**GLOBAL BENCHMARK**  
Meanwhile, among global technology and consulting companies, Microsoft spent \$32.5 billion on R&D in 2025, representing 12 per cent of total revenue. IBM invested \$8.3 billion in R&D in 2025, while Accenture reported R&D expenditure of approximately \$0.8 billion in FY25. "For decades, the model rewarded execution speed and cost efficiency, not lab-

funded curiosity. Clients came with defined problems; the job was to solve them fast. That mindset shaped investment decisions for years. But AI, automation, cloud and cybersecurity are changing what clients expect from technology partners altogether. The conversation has moved from 'Can you deliver this?' to 'Can you think ahead of this?' This demands a fundamentally different investment posture," Praveen Joshi, MD & founding member of RSK Business Solutions, explained. "Treating R&D purely as an overhead misses its strategic value. When it leads to reusable automation frameworks, stronger AI capabilities or proprietary delivery accelerators, it becomes a competitive advantage rather than a cost. While margins may face short-term pressure, the long-term gains can outweigh the investment," he said.

# Iran and US trade strikes, Kuwait comes under fire as diplomacy drags on

**Reuters**  
Dubai



A man holds an Iranian flag near an anti-US billboard depicting Donald Trump and the Strait of Hormuz **REUTERS**

Iran and the US said they had both carried out strikes on military targets, and each accused the other of acting aggressively as diplomatic efforts to end three months of war drag on. The US military said it had, at the weekend, struck Iranian air defences, a ground control station and two drones that were threatening ships after "aggressive Iranian actions", including shooting down a US drone over international waters. Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) said on Monday it had targeted an air base used by the US in response to an attack on southern Iran. It did not identify the base, but Kuwait activated air defences on Monday and denounced Iranian missile and drone attacks, which it said were undermining efforts to reduce tensions in the region.

**TRUMP'S CALL**  
In a late-night social media post, US President Donald Trump did not mention the exchange of hostilities, repeating his assertion that Iran "really wants to make a deal". He berated critics, including what he described as "seemingly unpatriotic Republicans", for negative "chirping" about negotiations to end the conflict. "Just sit back and relax; it will all work out well in the end - It always does!" he said. Despite Trump's remarks, Iranian Foreign Ministry spokesperson Esmail Baghaei accused Washington on Monday of constantly shifting its negotiating stance and condemned what he called US aggressive action. "Negotiations have started amid severe suspicion and mistrust, and the exchange of messages is taking place in this atmosphere," Baghaei said. "The other party is constantly changing its views and putting forward new or contradictory demands (...) it is natural that this situation will prolong negotiations," he said, adding that Tehran viewed Israeli actions in the region, including in Lebanon, as inseparable from those of the US.

pushing up energy prices since Iran effectively closed the Strait of Hormuz, a vital global supply route for oil and liquefied natural gas.

# Tractor Junction's FY26 revenue up 62% at ₹198 crore, announces ESOP buyback

**Our Bureau**  
Bengaluru



Rajat Gupta, CEO and Founder, Tractor Junction

Tractor Junction, a rural auto-fintech platform, said on Monday that its revenues grew 62 per cent during FY26 to touch ₹ 198.4 crore. The company attracted over 6 crore visitors to its platform during the year. Building on that momentum, the company is eyeing a doubling of its growth for FY27, targeting ₹400 crore in revenue, Tractor Junction said in a statement.

**EQUITY PAYOUT**  
The company also announced its second ESOP liquidity programme worth ₹3 crore, allowing 80 eligible employees to exercise their vested options. "FY26 was a defining year for us — revenue grew 62 per cent to nearly ₹200 crore, our platform crossed 6 crore visitors, and the

fintech arm FINJ scaled to an annual disbursal run rate of nearly ₹3,333 crore. The people who built this momentum deserve to share in the value they have created. This second ESOP buyback is a recognition of their work and a signal of the conviction we have in the road ahead. With clear unit economics, a deep rural moat and a sharper product engine, we are now setting ourselves the ambition of ₹400 crore in FY27 — more than 2x our FY26 base," Rajat Gupta, CEO and

Founder, Tractor Junction, said in a statement. Tractor Junction partners with over 50 original equipment manufacturers across tractors, commercial vehicles, three-wheelers and two-wheelers, and operates an on-ground retail network across 85 cities in six States. Its fintech arm FINJ, which was launched in January 2024, now operates across 17 States with over 35 lender partners and over 19,000 channel partners. The company said that it is on a strong growth trajectory and is currently hiring for more than 500 positions across all its businesses and geographies. **GROWTH CAPITAL** Tractor Junction raised ₹200 crore (\$22.6 million) in Series A in November 2025, led by global impact investor Astanor, with participation from existing investors Info Edge and Omnivore.

# Cognizant creates new job roles for next-generation AI talent

**Our Bureau**  
Chennai



Cognizant on Monday announced the creation of two new job categories — the frontier certified engineer and frontier business operator — purpose-built for the AI era. The company said the roles are designed for a new generation of talent at the forefront of enterprise AI transformation. Both roles are developed and certified through SkillSpring, Cognizant's proprietary training platform. **ROLE REDESIGN** Frontier engineers will work directly with client organisations to realign business processes for an AI environment. "The role requires both strategic thinking and technical fluency, making it one of the most consequential pivot points into the AI-era workforce," Cognizant said.

Frontier business operators will be tasked with taking full ownership of operational results; they will manage a blended workforce of human and digital agents to drive business outcomes. "We are making a deliberate bet on the next generation," Kathy Diaz, Chief Hu-

man Resources Officer of Cognizant, said. "SkillSpring gives us the ability to rapidly develop associates who can lead in an AI-first environment." Cognizant CEO Ravi Kumar S said in a LinkedIn post that the urgency for such roles is clear. "Consider that 65 per cent of tasks analysed across 1,000+ professions globally are exposed to AI-led change, yet less than 10 per cent of AI capabilities are fully implemented in enterprises today. This stark AI velocity gap creates immense opportunity for those ready to act," he said.

# Why dairy must lead India's gender-justice agenda

Empowering women in dairy can strengthen livelihoods and drive inclusive rural growth



**BRAHMANI NARA**



**MILKING PROGRESS.** Women are not only the backbone of India's dairy sector; they are its lifeblood

In India, where dairy underpins rural livelihoods and provides daily employment to millions of women, placing women at the centre of dairy policy is not only fair and legitimate but also essential to building economic resilience and inclusive growth. Reflecting this urgency, the United Nations has declared 2026 the "International Year of the Woman Farmer", calling on governments and industries to address gender gaps in land rights, access to finance and extension services. **WHY IT MATTERS** Women are not only the backbone of India's dairy sector; they are its lifeblood. They shoulder milking, animal care, fodder collection and household nutrition, yet their contributions remain inadequately recognised in official records, markets and ownership systems. When women are excluded from procurement lists or payment channels, their ability to negotiate, reinvest and plan is diminished. Dairy is uniquely positioned to lead India's gender-justice agenda because it is labour-intensive, village-based and already heavily reliant on women's work. Direct village-level sourcing removes intermediaries, bringing producers

closer to markets and reducing avoidable costs. Registering women as producers would make their work visible, while direct payments into their bank accounts would strengthen their financial independence and help build creditworthiness. With easier access to loans, women would be better placed to invest in animal health and feed, improving both productivity and livelihoods. Together, these measures would also increase women's earnings. Yet significant barriers remain. In many parts of India, men continue to own most land and livestock, limiting women's ability to use assets as collateral for loans. Many women lack the legal documents required to access formal credit. Training programmes are often held at times or in locations that women cannot attend because of household responsibilities or exclusionary male-dominated forums. **GENDER-AWARE POLICY** A gender-responsive dairy policy will transform sys-

tems by eliminating barriers and empowering women. In particular, such a policy will officially register women in the documentation and payment systems, facilitate livestock ownership, and provide financial services and loans that cater to women's needs. Some firms in India have already shown what this can look like in practice. One organisation, for instance, decentralised procurement so that women ran 40 per cent of village centres. By introducing easy-term loans to village entrepreneurs, with a substantial share reaching women dairy farmers, the organisation showed how targeted last-mile finance can unlock enterprise growth. Appointing women as procurement representatives and encouraging their participation in village meetings strengthened their voice, while continuous training and mentorship helped them build sustainable dairy enterprises. The model also extends beyond primary produc-

tion; women-run franchise models can connect women entrepreneurs to downstream sales and distribution. **WORK AHEAD** Dairy firms can go further by formally registering women as producers and paying them directly. They can support women-led producer groups, offer tailored services such as fodder banks and insurance, and expand access to affordable credit through village institutions and digital platforms. **ACCOUNTABILITY** Many companies are already taking meaningful steps to support women farmers. To deepen accountability and accelerate progress, they should regularly report the gender outcomes of these efforts. Such disclosures should track practical indicators, including the number of women engaged, payments made directly to women, access to credit, women's representation in decision-making roles, changes in income and time saved. India's dairy future will be stronger, fairer and more resilient if it embraces innovation and a gender-responsive approach. That means recognising women's labour, expanding direct payments, improving access to credit and supporting women-led enterprise at the village level. The author is the Executive Director of Heritage Foods Ltd. Views expressed are personal.



**एनएमडीसी**  
**NMDC**  
Responsible Mining



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**STANDALONE & CONSOLIDATED AUDITED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER AND YEAR ENDED 31<sup>ST</sup> MARCH, 2026**

Pursuant to regulation 47 of the SEBI (Listing obligations and disclosure requirement) Regulations, 2015

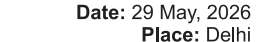
The results can be accessed through the following link  
[https://www.nmdc.co.in/cms-admin/Upload/Financial\\_Result\\_Document/2b078d60fd6f430287361c214e7b5854\\_20260529205647560.pdf](https://www.nmdc.co.in/cms-admin/Upload/Financial_Result_Document/2b078d60fd6f430287361c214e7b5854_20260529205647560.pdf)  
or scan



| FY26 HIGHLIGHTS |                          | FY26 Q4 HIGHLIGHTS |                          |
|-----------------|--------------------------|--------------------|--------------------------|
| 33%             | TURNOVER<br>₹ 31,554 Cr. | 61%                | TURNOVER<br>₹ 11,173 Cr. |
| 11%             | PAT<br>₹ 7,421 Cr.       | 35%                | PAT<br>₹ 2,020 Cr.       |
| 21%             | PRODUCTION<br>53.16 MnT  | 22%                | PRODUCTION<br>16.27 MnT  |
| 13%             | SALES<br>50.24 MnT       | 21%                | SALES<br>15.30 MnT       |

**NMDC Limited**  
(A Government of India Enterprise)

HEAD OFFICE: KHANU BHAVAN, MASAB TANK, HYDERABAD - 500028, INDIA.

CIN: L13100TG1958GOI001674 | [www.nmdc.co.in](http://www.nmdc.co.in) | FOLLOW US ON: 

By order of the Board NMDC Limited  
sd/-  
**(Amitava Mukherjee)**  
Chairman-Cum-Managing Director  
DIN: 08265207  
Date: 29 May, 2026  
Place: Delhi



QUICKLY.

**Gold falls with inflation worries rising**



Gold prices fell nearly 2 per cent on Monday as escalating tensions in the Middle East heightened inflation concerns and reinforced expectations that central banks may keep monetary policy tighter for longer. Spot gold was down 1.9 per cent at \$4,451.65 per ounce as 1401 GMT. US gold futures fell 2.5 per cent to \$4,479.20. Silver fell 1.7 per cent to \$73.96. REUTERS

**Crude oil up on rising geopolitical tensions**

**London:** Crude oil prices rose more than 3 per cent after Iran and the US traded strikes and Israel ordered troops to move further into Lebanon. Brent futures were up \$2.68 at \$93.80 a barrel at 1121 GMT. US WTI rose \$3.03 to \$90.39. REUTERS

**Aluminium hits 4-year high on fresh supply risks**



**London:** Aluminium prices soared to their highest point in more than four years as Middle East supply risks escalated after the US and Iran traded military strikes, traders said. Benchmark aluminium on the LME traded 0.5 per cent higher at \$3,685 a tonne. The Middle East houses 9 per cent of global smelting capacity for aluminium. Copper was up 1.5 per cent at \$13,840. REUTERS

# Govt lowers kharif fertilizer demand as IMD forecasts deficit monsoon rainfall

**TAKING STOCK.** Agriculture Ministry steps in after 20% of fertilizer subsidy had been exhausted in first two months

**Prabhudatta Mishra**  
New Delhi

On a day the Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan launched a month-long farmer awareness campaign to reduce chemical fertilizers by engaging agriculture scientists in extension work, which is normally overseen by the States, the Centre announced that the demand for the five major crop nutrients has been reduced for the kharif season. Briefing the media on the fertilizer situation after the geopolitical crises deepened with the Iran war on February 28, Aparna S Sharma, Additional Secretary in the Department of Fertilizers, said 20 per cent of the subsidy allocated for FY27 had been exhausted in the first two months of the current fiscal. But, she said that the Department of Fertilizers would raise the demand with the Finance Ministry as and when the subsidy is spent.



**WAR EFFECT.** The subsidy may top ₹3 lakh crore in the current fiscal if the problem in West Asia persists till the end of kharif

In the 2026-27 Budget, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman had provided ₹1,70,944.53 crore for fertilizer subsidy, including ₹1,16,805 crore for the urea sector (both domestic and imported) and ₹54,000 crore for the phosphorus (P) and potash (K) sectors. In 2025-26, the fertilizer subsidy was pegged at ₹1,86,630.63 crore (Revised Estimate), which has since gone up due to the war-induced surge in global rates from March 1.

**MONSOON IMPACT** The fertilizer subsidy may exceed ₹3 lakh crore in the current fiscal if the problem in West Asia persists till the end of kharif because of the current high global prices of raw materials as well as finished products, an official said last week. He said that the subsidy could even reach ₹3.5 lakh crore if the current situation — high global prices and closure of the Strait of Hormuz — continues through the rabi season.

Sharma said that in view of the “below normal” monsoon forecast by the India Meteorological Department and the threat of El Nino, the Agriculture Ministry had lowered its demand estimate for the kharif season. Accordingly, urea demand, which was previously estimated to be 19.4 million tonnes (mt), has been cut to 19 mt, she said. The IMD had actually forecast the monsoon rainfall to be “below normal” as early as in mid-April, and it recently reduced the quantity of rainfall by 2 percentage points — from 92 per cent of the long period average (LPA) to 90 per cent.

India’s fertilizer production was 10.48 mt post the West Asia crisis and with imports of 2.76 mt, total availability reached 13.24 mt during March-May, she said. Meanwhile, Chouhan on Monday launched the nationwide “*Khet Bachao Abhiyan*” (Save the soil) from Ramasiya village in Madhya Pradesh under his parliamentary constituency. He appealed to the farmers to avoid the indiscriminate use of chemical fertilizers and pesticides and instead apply manure according to the soil’s requirements based on test results. In the Inter-Ministerial briefing on the impact of the West Asia crisis on different sectors, Anupam Mishra, Additional Secretary in the Department of Consumer Affairs, said that the prices of cereals, pulses and sugar had remained stable, while that of potato, onion and tomato are range-bound, with no unusual volatility reported in the essential commodities.

**PLEA TO FARMERS** The Additional Secretary said that fertilizer stocks stand at 51 per cent of the requirement for the kharif season, which is higher than the conventionally maintained 33 per cent due to advance stocking and improved logistics management.

# Seafood exports clock \$8.46 b in FY26 despite global headwinds; volumes hit a record high of 19.72 lt

**Our Bureau**  
Kochi

Defying global market headwinds, India’s seafood exports touched a record high of ₹73,890.46 crore (\$8.46 billion) in FY26, registering a 13.44 per cent increase in value. Export volumes rose to a record high of 19.72 lakh tonnes (lt). Marine Products Export Development Authority (Mpeda) Chairman P Jawa-

har said the country achieved its highest-ever seafood export volume and value during the fiscal year, with the United States and China continuing to be key markets. **FROZEN SHRIMP** Frozen shrimp remained the top seafood export, earning ₹49,037.93 crore (\$5.62 billion) and accounting for 40.19 per cent of volume and 66.52 per cent of earnings. Exports of frozen shrimp

stood at 7,92,647 tonnes. The US was the largest importer of Indian frozen shrimp at 2,56,128 tonnes, followed by China (1,69,505 tonnes), the European Union (1,35,599 tonnes), South-East Asia (83,810 tonnes), Japan (40,776 tonnes) and West Asia (30,478 tonnes). Frozen fish was the second-largest export category, generating ₹5,658.37 crore (\$643.7 million), while dried marine products earned ₹5,079.09

crore (\$577.44 million). Exports of frozen squid reached 1,02,060 tonnes worth ₹4,493.80 crore (\$513.84 million), while frozen cuttlefish exports totalled 67,157 tonnes, valued at \$331.96 million. **US LEADS BY VALUE** The US remained India’s largest seafood market by value, importing 2,79,193 tonnes worth ₹20,263.27 crore (\$2.33 billion). However, shipments to the US de-

clined by 10.82 per cent in rupee terms, 14.22 per cent in dollar terms and 19.51 per cent in volume. China emerged as the largest destination by volume, importing 4,90,369 tonnes worth \$1.61 billion. The European Union retained its position as the third-largest market with imports worth \$1.59 billion, followed by South-East Asia (\$1.35 billion), Japan (\$452.91 million) and West Asia (\$283 million).

# Cotton eases after govt suspends import duty

**Vishwanath Kulkarni**  
Bengaluru

Domestic cotton prices eased further after the government announced the removal of duty on imports from June 1 till October 30, while futures on the ICE gained marginally on Monday. Following the announcement, a section of mills booked some quantity for import, sources said. On Monday, the Cotton Corporation of India (CCI) reduced its sale price by ₹700 per candy (356 kg) for the 2025-26 crop on Monday. But the State-run entity received a muted response with demand of around 700 bales (of 170 kg each), mainly from the millers segment, sources said. Cotton futures on the ICE were up 1.68 per cent to around 77.44 cents per pound on Monday. “Do-

mestic prices are under pressure as buyers are quiet. Moreover, with duty free imports allowed, buyers have more options. They can import or buy from domestic resellers, CCI and MNCs,” said Ramanuj Das Boob, a sourcing agent in Raichur. **ICE PRICES UP 47%** In recent months, cotton prices had surged following the global price trend. ICE cotton futures gained around 47 per cent since early February to touch 88 cents per pound on May 11, and have eased in the recent days and are hovering around 77 cents. Anand Popat of CotYarn Tradelink said the duty removal would benefit the spinning industry as spinners would be able to import cotton from any origin, and export yarn at more competitive prices. As the textiles sector would gain easier ac-



**The CCI cut prices by another ₹700/candy post duty removal**

cess to contamination-free cotton, enabling production of higher-quality yarn and finished products, it would thereby result in the likely increase of yarn, fabrics and textile products, he said. Popat said new import contracts are expected to start arriving in India during the second half of July, and consumption may increase due to improved availability of imported cotton and

wider range of quality options. Further, the availability of imported cotton could influence domestic price trends, and Indian cotton may become less sensitive to rising ICE cotton futures. **AREA MAY RISE** On Friday, the CCI resumed cotton sale and cut prices by ₹2,300 per candy. Having procured about 105 lakh bales, the State-run agency has already sold a major portion, with stocks estimated around 32 lakh bales. It initially offered the 2025-26 MSP-procured crop at about ₹57,200/candy, later reduced prices to around ₹54,600, and subsequently raised them gradually to as high as ₹68,600 per candy. Meanwhile, the Cotton Association of India expects acreage to increase by around 7 per cent in the upcoming kharif season, driven by remunerative prices.

# Wheat buys for buffer stocks top revised target

**Prabhudatta Mishra**  
New Delhi

The Union government’s wheat procurement during the ongoing season has reached 34.99 million tonnes (mt) as of May 31 — up 17 per cent from 29.82 mt in the corresponding period a year ago. The current procurement, made by the Food Corporation of India for buffer stocks, has exceeded the target of 34.5 mt set by the government. In 2025, the government had procured 30 mt of wheat, but it expected higher purchases after the Agriculture Ministry estimated the production at a record high of 120.21 mt. Last week, the Agriculture Ministry further enhanced the wheat output estimate to 120.66 mt, notwithstanding the localised damage caused

|                  | Wheat procurement* (lakh tonnes) |               |             |
|------------------|----------------------------------|---------------|-------------|
|                  | 2025                             | 2026          | % Change    |
| Madhya Pradesh   | 77.75                            | 104.37        | 34.24       |
| Rajasthan        | 19.8                             | 24.32         | 22.8        |
| Uttar Pradesh    | 10.25                            | 17.21         | 67.9        |
| Haryana          | 70.83                            | 81.21         | 14.7        |
| Punjab           | 119.24                           | 121.63        | 2.0         |
| Bihar^           | 17,923                           | 36,285        | 102.4       |
| <b>All India</b> | <b>298.2</b>                     | <b>349.92</b> | <b>17.3</b> |

Source: CFFP Portal; \*In tonne; ^Until May 31

due to the unseasonal rain and hailstorms. According to the government’s third advance estimates of agriculture crops, the current projection of wheat production is higher by 2.3 per cent from 117.94 mt in 2024-25. **RELAXED NORMS** But the procurement data show that out of 34.99 mt so far bought by the government, 23.63 mt (or over 67 per cent) were procured under relaxed quality specifications. C Shikha, Joint Secretary

# Monsoon knocks on the door, but wait isn’t over

**Vinson Kurian**  
Thiruvananthapuram

Rain clouds are once again consolidating over the south-east Arabian Sea and Lakshadweep before advancing towards the Kerala coast, even though the monsoon itself is yet to move beyond Sunday’s position. On Monday afternoon, the northern limit of the monsoon continued to run just south of Kanniyakumari, extending through northern Sri Lanka before sweeping diagonally across the Bay of Bengal into Myanmar. The India Meteorological Department (IMD) said the conditions are favourable for the monsoon to advance further into parts of Lakshadweep, Kerala, Tamil Nadu, and adjoining areas of the Bay of Bengal over the next 2-3 days.

It has forecast very heavy rainfall over Kerala and Mahe for five days beginning Wednesday, coinciding with the expected window for the monsoon onset. Isolated to scattered light-to-moderate rain, thunderstorms, lightning and gusty winds of 40-50 km/hr are likely over Tamil Nadu, Puducherry, Karaikal, Kerala, Mahe, Lakshadweep and Telangana for the next four days.

**HEAVY RAIN FORECAST** Similar conditions are likely also over Lakshadweep for four days, interior Karnataka for three days, coastal Andhra Pradesh and Yanam for two days, and coastal Karnataka for three days from Wednesday. Looking further ahead, the European Centre for Medium-Range Weather Forecasts (ECMWF) indicates that rainfall over the next fortnight may remain concentrated along the coasts of Kerala and Karnataka, while also extending into parts of central Tamil Nadu, Rayalaseema and south coastal



**GATHERING MASS.** The monsoon clouds are consolidating over Lakshadweep and the adjoining seas. Andhra Pradesh. The outlook suggests that Mumbai may have to wait well beyond its usual monsoon onset date of June 10 for sustained rain.

**NO MJO SUPPORT** Meanwhile, there appears to be little support for the monsoon from the Madden-Julian Oscillation (MJO), the eastward-moving pulse of tropical convection that periodically enhances rainfall over the Indian Ocean. Forecasts show an incoming MJO weakening over the Western Hemisphere and Africa by June 19 before becoming indistinct through the rest of the month. Current guidance offers no clear indication of its return to the Indian Ocean in time to provide meaningful support to the monsoon. However, a 46-day outlook from the ECMWF (valid till July 13) from June to the middle of the rainiest month of July revealed an interesting pattern. Accumulated rainfall is shown to be the highest along the West Coast from Mumbai-Konkan to Goa, coastal Karnataka and Kerala as also over eastern Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, Odisha, West Bengal and eastern Bihar (400-500 mm). It will be 100-200 mm over Tamil Nadu, Karnataka, Rayalaseema, Telangana, Marathwada, west Madhya Pradesh and the entire Uttar Pradesh.

# Augmont debuts AI-powered gold evaluation machine in Chennai

**Our Bureau**  
Chennai

Augmont, one of India’s leading digital gold platforms, has launched an AI-powered gold purity evaluation machine at its Poonamallee gold loan branch in suburban Chennai, Tamil Nadu. Powered by advanced robotic and AI-led assessment technology, the machine enables customers to instantly evaluate the purity of their gold ornaments in a transparent, non-invasive and hassle-free manner, a statement from the company said.

**CUSTOMER JOURNEY** This AI-powered gold purity evaluation machine is designed to simplify the customer journey by combining instant purity evaluation with a seamless gold loan process through our inte-



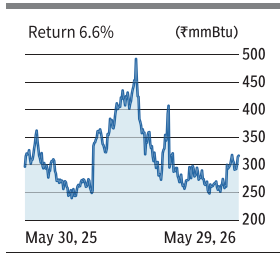
rated technology platform. Customers can now walk into a branch, evaluate their gold transparently and if they choose to, proceed with a gold loan within minutes. The facility enables customers to make more informed decisions regarding recycling or selling their gold based on transparent and technology-driven purity analysis, it said. **EVOLVING ECOSYSTEM** With sustainability and responsible consumption gain-

ing prominence, gold recycling is becoming an integral part of India’s evolving gold ecosystem. Recycling existing gold reduces dependence on imports and mining while unlocking value from idle household holdings. As the industry moves towards greater transparency and formalisation, accurate purity assessment is crucial in helping consumers make informed decisions on recycling, selling or pledging gold for loans. Ketan Kothari, Whole-Time Director, Augmont, said, “As demand for organised, transparent and trustworthy gold services grows, we wanted to introduce an innovation that strengthens consumer confidence and decision-making. Chennai is a key market for us, and this pilot will help us better understand consumer adoption and behaviour.”

# Buy natural gas if the price dips to ₹310

**Akhil Nallamuthu**  
bl. research bureau

Natural gas futures (₹321/mmBtu) rallied 14 per cent last week and closed at ₹316 on Friday. Now, the contract is trading above key levels at ₹308 and ₹318, showing a positive bias. **COMMODITY CALL.** Supporting the bullish bias, the chart shows that natural gas has been forming higher highs and higher lows since early May, and the price is also above the 21-day moving average. While the outlook is bullish at the moment, there is a chance for the contract to see a corrective decline in price, possibly to the ₹308-₹318 price band. After witnessing this correction, we expect natural



gas futures to see an upswing, which can lift the price to ₹340 and subsequently to ₹370. On the other hand, if the contract slips below the support at ₹308, we can expect the downtrend to extend to ₹285, a support. The next support is at ₹280. But as it stands, the outlook is bullish. Nevertheless, traders can buy if there is a dip in price rather than going long at the current level of ₹321. Buy natural gas if the price dips to ₹310. Target and stop-loss can be ₹340 and ₹295, respectively.

# Corteva rolls out Mavilon for pest management in rice

**Our Bureau**  
Bengaluru

Corteva has introduced Mavilon, a granular insecticide for pest management in rice cultivation in India. Rice, a daily staple and a cornerstone of India’s agricultural economy, faces persistent threats from pests such as Brown Planthopper (BPH) and stem borer, which can cause significant yield losses and reduce grain quality. Farmers often tackle these pests only after infestations become visible, a reactive approach that can limit effectiveness. Delayed detection frequently allows the damage to progress before corrective action is taken. Labour shortages during peak farming periods and reliance on rain-free windows



for spraying further add to the operational challenges at critical stages of the crop cycle. Applied once, 30-35 days after transplanting, Mavilon is designed to protect the crop before visible damage occurs. According to the company, its granular formulation provides up to 60 days of control against BPH and

up to 15 days against stem borer, helping safeguard the crop during key yield-forming stages. By enabling early intervention, Mavilon allows farmers to stay ahead of pest pressure rather than respond after the damage has begun. Beyond crop protection, Mavilon aims to reduce dependence on repeated foliar sprays, lowering operational complexity and minimising the need for last-minute interventions. This can help farmers improve efficiency while achieving more predictable outcomes each season. Mavilon reinforces Corteva’s commitment to delivering science-based and sustainable crop protection solutions that support crop health and enhance grower profitability across India, the company said.



QUICKLY.

Karnataka Bank hosts  
auditors conference

**Mangaluru:** Karnataka Bank organised its annual conference of Concurrent Auditors and Internal Auditors for 2026-27 in Mangaluru recently. Raghavendra S Bhat, Managing Director and CEO of Karnataka Bank, emphasised the critical role of auditors in promoting transparency and sustainable growth. A media statement said that the conference served as a platform for discussing strengthening audit practices, enhancing risk management, and regulatory compliance.

South Coast Railway zone  
with Vizag HQ on track

**Hyderabad:** The 18<sup>th</sup> Zone of Indian Railways, South Coast Railway (SCoR), formally commenced operations on Monday with Visakhapatnam as its headquarters. The Ministry of Railways issued a gazette notification for the zone on May 4, 2026, paving the way for its full operationalisation from June 1, 2026.

AIONOS, Black Box pact  
to boost AI Applications

**Mumbai:** Black Box and AIONOS announced a strategic alliance on Monday to help enterprises accelerate AI transformation; from infrastructure build-out to measurable business outcomes. Both will work on expanding go-to-market opportunities across India, North America, EMEA and APAC, with a key focus on India's rapidly expanding Global Capability Centre ecosystem. AIONOS' Co-Founder and Vice Chairman CP Gurnani, said the success of the pact depends on whether the products put together lead to a triple digit number in millions of dollars in the next three years.

# 'RBI move to curb mobile wallets may hit viability of high volume use cases'

**DRAWING LINES.** Idea could be to clearly differentiate wallets from banking products, ensure tighter norms

**Jyoti Banthia**  
Bengaluru

A proposed tightening of mobile wallet regulations by the Reserve Bank of India is forcing fintech companies to revisit business plans built around prepaid payment instruments (PPIs), a segment that has continued to grow even as UPI dominates digital payments. Industry executives said the draft framework issued on April 22 could restrict several wallet-led offerings and slow growth in a category that processed 69.50crore transactions worth ₹22,448 crore by 11 crore users in March.

"The proposals materially reduce the flexibility that wallets currently offer consumers. If implemented without modifications, several high-volume use cases may become commercially unviable," said the founder of a fintech firm, requesting

anonymity. Among the key proposals, the RBI has capped person-to-person wallet transfers at ₹25,000 per month, reduced the cash loading limit to ₹10,000 from ₹50,000, and imposed an overall monthly balance ceiling of ₹2 lakh.

The regulator has also proposed restricting minimum-KYC wallets to payments for goods and services, effectively barring their use for person-to-person transfers.

**ENTRY-LEVEL WALLETS**

"Many customers use entry-level wallets before completing full KYC requirements. Removing remittance functionality at this stage could impact adoption and disrupt existing domestic transfer models built around wallets," said a senior payments industry executive.

Industry participants are expected to seek a phased implementation timeline



**BREATHING SPACE.** The industry is hoping the rollout is deferred by 6-12 months to allow firms adequate time to adapt

and broader consultations with stakeholders before the rules are finalised. Some executives suggested that the roll out should be deferred by six to twelve months to allow companies adequate time to adapt.

The proposals could particularly affect wallet-focused companies such as Mobikwik, while Paytm continues efforts to restore its wallet business after regulatory action against Paytm Payments Bank. Executives

**Minimum-KYC wallets to be restricted to payments for goods and services, effectively barring person-to-person transfers**

also expressed concerns over the future of wallet interoperability through UPI. While the framework for wallet-based UPI payments has been introduced, pending clarity around interchange arrangements has limited adoption.

Some industry executives believe the regulator's move may be aimed at addressing practices such as credit-linked wallet products, co-branded card-like offerings and the proliferation of mul-

## West Bengal CM expands Cabinet to 41, portfolio allocation likely tomorrow



**EXPANDING TEAM.** Governor RN Ravi administering the oath of office to BJP MLAs during the swearing-in ceremony at Lok Bhavan in the presence of Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari

**Our Bureau**  
Kolkata

West Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari expanded the Council of Ministers on Monday by inducting 35 newly-elected legislators, three weeks after the BJP formed its first-ever government in the State.

Thirteen Cabinet Ministers, including Swapan Dasgupta, Tapas Roy, Saradwat Mukherjee and Shankar Ghosh, were sworn in at the Lok Bhawan. Three Ministers of State with independent charge and 19 Ministers of State also took oath.

The portfolio allocation is expected to be announced on Wednesday.

After the induction of the 35 MLAs into the Council of Ministers, the State Cabinet strength now stands at 41.

Adhikari was sworn in as the Chief Minister of West Bengal on May 9, after the BJP recorded a landslide victory in the Assembly elections in April.

The Cabinet expansion was expected this week as Adhikari and State BJP Chief Samik Bhattacharya held meetings in Delhi with the party's central leadership last week about the induc-

tion of members in the council of Ministers.

**TO PROBE SCHEME**

On Monday, Adhikari said separate special investigation teams (SITs) will probe the alleged fake beneficiaries of "Lakshmir Bhandar", the women's cash transfer scheme of the previous Trinamool government, and the alleged forgery of MLAs' signatures in a letter submitted by the Trinamool Congress to the office of the Speaker on the Leader of Opposition in the Assembly.

"Around 30 lakh Lakshmir Bhandar accounts are fake. I have asked the Director General of Police to form an SIT to investigate the matter," Adhikari told mediapersons at the state secretariat, Nabanna.

He said a money laundering probe will also be conducted as it involves illegal cash transfers.

Those who were questioning the 12-page verification form for the new Annapurna Bhandar scheme, in which the financial assistance to women beneficiaries will be increased to ₹3,000 per month from ₹1,500, should take into account the alleged "irregularities" in the erstwhile Lakshmir Bhandar scheme, he added.

## Kedarnath shuttle copter operators seek fuel surcharge

**Aneesh Phadnis**  
Mumbai

Helicopter operators providing Kedarnath shuttle services have asked the Uttarakhand government to introduce a fuel surcharge to cover the cost of operations following a hike in aviation turbine fuel price.

**SHUTTLE SERVICES**

Shuttle services to Kedarnath are operated from three locations in Mandakini valley.



**FAST ACTION SOUGHT.** Fare hike requires immediate attention from the State government, say the operators

Ticket rates are approved by the Uttarakhand Civil Aviation Development Authority following a bid process.

These rates were approved before the fuel price

revision in April.

"Continued fare caps are now making operations unsustainable. Operators are facing mounting losses, threatening continuity of

services that are critical to pilgrims and the local economy," said Business Aircraft Operators Association president Harsh Vardhan Sharma.

**SHUTTLE SERVICE**

Eight companies operate helicopter services from helipads at Guptakashi, Phata and Sersi to Kedarnath.

Ticket prices vary from ₹6,300 to over ₹12,700 depending on the route. The shuttle service began from April 21 and will run till mid-June.

While oil companies have reduced ATF prices by 25 per cent from June 1, helicopter firms continue to face challenge.

Helicopter operators have been able to partially offset the costs for Chardham charter flights but ticket prices for shuttle service to Kedarnath has been pre-determined as per the bids.

An operator said, "As many seats are booked months earlier, it is difficult to revise prices. However, we have been able to raise ticket price for around 25 per cent of the passengers."

## CIL's output falls 11.6% to 56.1 mt in May

**Mithun Dasgupta**  
Kolkata

Coal India's total coal production in May fell 11.6 per cent year-on-year to 56.1 million tonnes as it focusses on liquidating stocks.

In May, coal offtake witnessed a 2.2 per cent y-o-y increase at 66.2 mt against 65.2 mt in the year-ago period, according to CIL's stock exchange filing on Monday. Coal production in May last year stood at 63.5 mt.

Among the company's seven coal-producing subsidiaries, five witnessed a y-o-y fall in production in May, with Eastern Coalfields Ltd reporting a 3.6 per cent drop, Bharat Coking Coal 25.5 per cent, Northern Coalfields 23.7 per cent, Western Coalfields 8.4 per cent and Mahanadi Coalfields 20.1 per cent y-o-y.

In a recent exclusive interview with *businessline*, Coal India Chairman and Managing Director B Sairam said



Coal India Chairman and Managing Director B Sairam

the company's emphasis is now on more efficient synchronisation between production and evacuation.

**FRESHER COAL**

"We are consciously making efforts to place fresher coal into the market and move towards a more demand-aligned produce-and-sell approach, rather than prolonged stocking before sale," Sairam had said.

CIL began this fiscal with around 130 mt of coal stock at its pitheads, which was 17 per cent of its entire output of around 768 mt last fiscal.

"Our effort is to progressively moderate the inventory levels towards more optimal levels of around 10 per cent of the total production, or around 70 mt," said Sairam.

**COAL INVENTORY**

At present, coal inventories at CIL's pitheads are at around 112 mt.

In April and May, coal offtake witnessed a 0.9 per cent y-o-y increase to 130.9 mt against 129.8 mt during the same period last year.

Coal India said its e-auction price of coal increased by 36 per cent over notified prices in May.

**E-AUCTION PRICE**

In April, the e-auction price rose by 51 per cent over notified prices.

Quantity offered through e-auction in May stood at 25.74 mt, while quantity allocated was 8.4 mt.

The quantity of coal allocated through the e-auction decreased 28.63 per cent on a month-on-month basis.

## As mobility norms tighten, ARAI is growing its testing capability from cars to metros

**Amit Vijay Mohile**  
Mumbai

India's largest automotive testing and certification agency, Pune-based ARAI, has begun validating metro carriage components testing and expand beyond cars and trucks into EV battery testing, vehicle crash safety, automotive software certification and compliance support for bus manufacturers.

Operating Under the Ministry of Heavy Industries, the agency recently tested an Obstacle & Derailment Detection (ODD) system for the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC).

ARAI is expanding capabilities aimed at helping automakers test safer vehicles, study EV battery fire risks and reduce dependence on expensive overseas crash-testing facilities. The broader objective is to help

companies prepare for tougher regulations expected, including stricter fuel-efficiency norms under CAFE III expected from April 2027, stronger EV battery safety rules under AIS-156, tougher crash-safety standards under Bharat NCAP and Euro NCAP, and new structural safety norms for buses under AIS 153 and GSR 159(E).

**CONVERGING TECH**

"Mobility technologies are increasingly converging across sectors," an ARAI official said. "Electric vehicles, metro systems and future connected mobility platforms now rely on similar batteries, software systems, sensors and electronic controls."

At ARAI's Pune testing centre, engineers recently recreated a high-impact emergency scenario for a Delhi Metro train using



ARAI's Obstacle & Derailment Detection validation

equipment normally associated with automotive crash testing. The project, carried out with metro rail major Alstom and engineering firm IPA, was aimed at validating the ODD system before deployment in real-world operations.

Meanwhile, AIS-156 battery safety norms have tightened testing requirements around battery overheating and thermal run-

away risks, while Bharat NCAP crash-safety norms are increasing pressure on manufacturers to improve passenger protection systems.

"Vehicle development cycles are becoming shorter while compliance requirements are becoming significantly more complex," another ARAI official said. "If testing and validation infrastructure does not expand in parallel, it can eventually slow down product development timelines for the industry."

ARAI has also launched a support programme for bus bodybuilders to help smaller operators comply with new safety regulations under GSR 159(E) notified in March 2024, and AIS 153. Structural safety certification is mandatory for larger passenger buses and require builders to clear inspections before vehicles registration.

## Uri I Stage-II hydropower unit in Kashmir achieves key milestone with start of tunnel excavation

**Gulzar Bhat**  
Srinagar

Construction activity gathered pace at the Uri-I Stage-II Hydroelectric Project in north Kashmir last week after engineers carried out the first controlled blast for excavation of an underground tunnel.

The hydropower project, coming up in Baramulla district, is expected to add 240 MW of generation capacity to Jammu and Kashmir.

Officials said the tunnel excavation work would facilitate the creation of critical underground structures required for power generation.

**POWER RESOURCES**

The project is being developed by NHPC at an estimated cost of over ₹2,700



**ENERGY PUSH.** The project is being developed by NHPC at an estimated cost of over ₹2,700 crore and will feature two generating units of 120 MW each

crore and will feature two generating units of 120 MW each.

Jammu and Kashmir possesses an estimated hydel generation potential of about 18,000 MW. Of this, nearly 14,900 MW has been identified for development, but less than a quarter has been tapped so far. The installed hydropower capacity

is about 3,540 MW spread across 31 projects managed by central and local agencies as well as independent power producers.

Four major projects with a combined capacity of more than 3,000 MW are expected to be commissioned by 2028, a move officials say could nearly double Jammu and Kashmir's existing hydro-

power output and strengthen its energy security.

Energy experts say the expansion of hydropower infrastructure is crucial for reducing the Union Territory's dependence on electricity imports, particularly during peak demand periods.

Official figures show that Jammu and Kashmir remains heavily dependent on power imports, during the winter months when electricity demand surges and local generation dips.

In December, more than 95 per cent of the region's electricity requirement was met through imports. During peak demand hours, power imports ranged between 2,900 MW and 3,100 MW, while imports during off-peak hours fluctuated between 2,400 MW and 2,800 MW.

## Now, snag hits launch of CBSE re-evaluation site

**Our Bureau**  
New Delhi

The operationalisation of verification and re-evaluation portal of the Central Board of Secondary Education, for Class 12 students, faced delays on Monday. The Board had earlier decided to postpone the operationalisation of the portal from May 29 to June 1 to ensure "highest standards and protocols of evaluation."

The portal remained inaccessible throughout the day and even till press time on Monday due to technical glitches.

In the afternoon, the CBSE, in a post on X, stated "Dear students, Verification and re-evaluation portal will go live soon. Official announcement will follow."

Ethical hacker Nisarga Adhikari, who has been flagging cybersecurity-related vul-



nerabilities on the OnMark portal, in a post on X on Monday claimed that the re-evaluation site "got taken down after he had reported an open payment info endpoint to Cert-IN."

**GLITCH-FREE PROCESS**

In a statement on May 29, the CBSE had said, "In order to ensure a transparent and glitch-free process for verification and re-evaluation of answer books of students who intend to submit their

**Portal remained inaccessible throughout the day and even till press time due to technical glitches**

applications on the Post-Result Activities portal, it has been decided that the designated portal will now be operational from 1st June 2026. This is to ensure the highest standards and protocols of evaluation."

The CBSE, which introduced the On Screen Marking System for the first time this year for Class 12<sup>th</sup> Board Exam, is under the scanner after students alleged discrepancies in its implementation.

Several students have reported inaccuracies in scoring mechanism while cases of a mismatch in roll num-

bers and scanned answer sheets also surfaced. Some students have also alleged missing pages in the scanned answer sheets.

Cybersecurity researchers have been flagging several vulnerabilities in the OnMark portal of the service provider of the CBSE.

The Board on Sunday said the vulnerabilities had been identified and said they have been contained.

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QUICKLY.

**Nvidia is taking on Intel and AMD with new AI chip**

Nvidia is entering the PC market with a new chip aimed at loosening the stranglehold of Intel. Starting this fall, Nvidia's new RTX Spark Superchip will debut in laptop and desktop computers from leading PC brands including Dell and Lenovo, CEO Jensen Huang said at the Computex trade show in Taipei. The product is a combination of microprocessor and graphics chip, built with MediaTek that will run Microsoft Windows for Arm operating system. **BLOOMBERG**

**Anthropic to deploy Mythos at first EU body**

Anthropic will give the European Union's cybersecurity body access to Mythos, the first EU agency to get access to the powerful AI tool that officials fear may be used to exploit vulnerabilities in key computer systems. Anthropic will let ENISA join Project Glasswing, an initiative to let key organisations test Mythos before it is released widely. **BLOOMBERG**

**India issues LoR to France for ₹3.25 lakh crore Rafale deal**

**Our Bureau**  
New Delhi

India has formally issued a letter of request (LoR) to France for the procurement of 114 Rafale fighter aircraft in a government-to-government deal estimated at ₹3.25 lakh crore.

According to Defence Ministry sources, the Acquisition Wing sent the request to the French government, initiating the next phase of negotiations. Of the 114 aircraft, 94 are expected to be manufactured in India through a partnership between Dassault Aviation and an Indian company. The French side is expected to respond within

**Zee Entertainment bags FIFA World Cup broadcasting rights**

**GAME ON.** Deal covers World Cups, youth tournaments and digital streaming rights from 2026 to 2034

**Vallari Sanzgiri**  
Mumbai

Concluding a significant battle in India's media space, Zee Entertainment Enterprises Ltd on Monday confirmed an 8-year agreement with Fédération Internationale de Football Association (FIFA) to broadcast marquee events such as the FIFA World Cup 2026 and 2030 editions, the FIFA Women's World Cup in 2027, and other content.

In addition to the FIFA World Cup 2026 that kicks off on June 11, Zee secured rights to events through 2034 along with docu-series content for the Indian market.

**RIGHTS PACKAGE**

Until recently, FIFA was in talks with Zee and JioStar for the media rights to its events,

with the latter offering \$20-25 million for the media rights to a single FIFA World Cup event.

Sources said the deal was finalised between \$25 and 80 million, significantly lower than the \$100 million hoped by FIFA initially, as per sources.

The deal includes content such as the FIFA Men's U-17 World Cup (2026-2034), FIFA Women's U-17 World Cup (2026-2034), FIFA U-20 Men's World Cup (2027, 2029, 2031 and 2033), FIFA U-20 Women's World Cup (2026, 2028, 2030, 2032 and 2034), FIFA Futsal Men's World Cup (2028 and 2032), FIFA Futsal Women's World Cup (2029 and 2033), FIFA Women's World Cup (2027) and FIFA Intercontinental Cup (2026-2030).

"The company has emerged as one of the most



**DIGITAL PITCH.** The content will also be aired on Zee's digital entertainment platform Zee 5 in multiple languages

powerful sports destinations for the youth of our nation by partnering with FIFA," said Zee in a press release.

The content will also be aired on Zee's digital entertainment platform Zee 5 in multiple languages.

"The investments in garnering the media rights and launching dedicated sports channels reflect our clear belief in its long-term potential. Our partnership with FIFA will enable us to unlock the

true value of the sport in line with our focus on growth and profitability," said Punit Goenka, CEO, Zee Entertainment Enterprises Ltd.

**GREAT OPPORTUNITY**

For Zee, the development presents a great opportunity to get massive paid subscribers and position itself as a serious player in sports broadcasting by signing up for future years, said Ajimon Francis, Managing Director

**PE-VC deal flows see marginal slowdown in May amid geopolitical uncertainty**

**Our Bureau**  
Chennai

Private equity and venture capital (PE-VC) deal flow continues to be tepid as global macroeconomic situation makes private investors cautious.

PE-VC investments for May stood at \$2.2 billion compared to \$1.8 billion in May 2025, data from Venture Intelligence show.

**DEAL DYNAMICS**

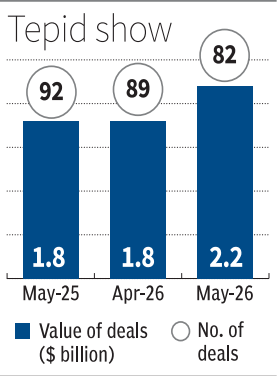
However, the deal count reduced from 92 in May 2025 to 82 in May 2026 and rise in high-value deals in May 2026

pushed up the overall tally. While the number of early-stage deals grew from 33 in May 2025 to 40 in May 2026, the growth-stage deal flow slowed from 41 to 20 in the same month.

May 2026 saw mega (over \$100 million) deals of \$1.5 billion compared to 3 such deals valued at \$0.6 billion in the same month last year.

The year has recorded 540 deals worth around \$14.9 billion (YTD till June) compared to 1,327 deals aggregating to \$37 billion in whole of 2025.

Global investment firm Carlyle's investment in healthcare revenue cycle



Source: Venture Intelligence

management platform Equalize (\$300 million), North Star Energy's raise of \$300 million from British In-

ternational Investment and Rapido's \$240 million raise from Accel and WestBridge were among major deals in May 2026.

**CASCADING EFFECT**

The West Asia crisis has impacted IPOs, especially the new-age tech companies, with many of which are now either on hold or withdrawn, Arun Natarajan, Founder and MD, Venture Intelligence, said. "This is having a cascading effect on the private markets too," he added.

Larger PE players are continuing to buy at attractive valuations but pre-IPO funding has dried up, he said.



daCumba/AB/1104

**IIT-M study sees 2 million XR jobs by 2030 in India**

**G Mahalakshmi**  
Chennai

The Extended Realities (XR) sector has the potential to generate around 2 million high value jobs by 2030, a study by IIT-Madras has found. The report, released on Monday by the Experiential Technology Innovation Centre (XTIC), analysed the Tamil Nadu AVGC-XR Policy 2026 and recommends the creation of an integrated "XR Corridor" or "XR Superhighway" that combines XR innovation, skill development and manufacturing centres. More than 1,000 start-ups and 1,000 SMEs operate in the sector.



focus on game engine development, original intellectual property creation, R&D and AI-driven immersive technologies.

India can reduce import dependence by leveraging Tamil Nadu's existing electronics and manufacturing corridors to build indigenous capabilities in the areas of head-mounted displays, trackers and haptic interfaces, thus strengthening India's position in the global XR hardware value chain, the report said. Prof M Manivanan, XTIC faculty, said in a statement, "We propose the creation of a State-level compute infra such as a 'TN-XR Cloud', which would provide subsidised access to high-end graphics processing units." He recommended making academia the anchor of the XR innovation ecosystem.

The writer is an intern

**Wockhardt to go solo in marketing its novel antibiotic**

**PT Jyothi Datta**  
Mumbai



**BILLION-DOLLAR BET.** The addressable antibiotic segment is about \$9 billion, according to industry estimates. The peak annual sales potential of the drug is about 1.5 billion

Drug maker Wockhardt will go solo in marketing Zaynich, the company's novel antibiotic that has received regulatory approval in the US — a first for a new chemical entity developed from India, its Founder and Chairman Habil Khorakiwala said.

The company recently received a green signal from the United States Food and Drug Administration (USFDA) for Zaynich (cefepime and zidebactam), an intravenous antibiotic to treat adults with complicated urinary tract infections (cUTI).

But unlike the usual modus operandi in pharmaceuticals to partner for global distribution, Wockhardt will market the drug in international markets and India on its own, Khorakiwala said in a select media interaction.

The USFDA approval for an Indian NCE marks a milestone for the company and for the Indian industry, he said. It was also significant

hardt. Chief Medical Officer, said, "The threat of drug-resistant infections is an escalating crisis, leaving clinicians with fewer tools to treat patients facing these aggressive pathogens."

**TRIAL DETAILS**

Zaynich (cefepime and zidebactam) is an injectable antibiotic comprising cefepime, a cephalosporin antibacterial drug and zidebactam, a non-lactam antibacterial and lactamase inhibitor, the company said. In the US, Zaynich had received the Qualified Infectious Disease Product (QIDP) and Fast Track designations from the FDA. It was also made available through expanded access programmes in multiple countries, including the US, for patients with limited treatment options, the company said.

The FDA approval was based, in part, on the results from ENHANCE-1, a Phase 3, randomised, double-blind, multi-centre study which evaluated the efficacy, safety and tolerability of Zaynich, compared with meropenem

in the treatment of hospitalised adults with cUTI or acute pyelonephritis (AP), it said. The study enrolled 530 patients from the US, Europe, LATAM, China and India, and spanned across 64 sites.

The product is contraindicated in patients with a known history of serious hypersensitivity to the components of Zaynich (cefepime and zidebactam) or other beta-lactam antibacterial drugs, the company said, citing adverse events.

Unlike most other beta-lactam combinations, Zaynich targets multiple penicillin-binding proteins (PBP 1a/b, 2 and 3) simultaneously, a note from the company said.

"This unique, multi-target synergy provides bactericidal activity against the most challenging drug-resistant Gram-negative bacteria for which there are currently very limited treatment options," it added.

cUTI is responsible for over 600,000 hospitalisations in the US annually, Wockhardt said.

**Brands, retailers betting big on premiumisation strategy**

**Meenakshi Verma Ambwani**  
New Delhi



Brands are capitalising on consumer demand for value-added products

Leading brands and retailers in categories such as footwear, apparel, accessories and beauty are betting big on premiumisation strategy.

The move comes as they are raking up higher growth rates in premium over mass segments as Indian consumers are increasingly willing to shell more on value-added products.

In a recent interaction with *businessline*, Gunjan Shah, MD & CEO, Bata India said premiumisation is among the key growth pillars for the company. "Premium brands such as Hush Puppies are outpacing the overall company growth. We have seen that consumers are willing to shell out even two times more for value-added products. The share of premium products to overall sales has also been growing, and we expect the premium

segment to continue to grow faster than mass segment. So we will continue to focus on the premiumisation strategy backed by solid marketing investments," he added.

Footwear companies such as Bata are witnessing strong shift towards casualisation and sneakerisation. But footwear is not alone. Take for instance Shoppers Stop which has identified five categories for its premiumisation bet.

On the earnings call last month, Kavindra Mishra — Customer Care Associate, MD and CEO, Shoppers Stop

Ltd, said that the company is going to "double down" on premiumisation as a strategy.

"Growth rate of premium and premium plus categories are far higher than the weighted average growth rate of Shoppers Stop. And in this journey of premiumisation, we have identified watches, beauty, handbags, footwear and shades as power categories," he added.

Anchit Nayar, Executive Director & Chief Executive Officer-Beauty at FSN E-Commerce Ventures Ltd, pointed out that the company has been witnessing premiumisation of beauty as a key trend.

In a recent earnings call, he said consumers are expected to evolve and embrace premium beauty brands, as their shopping behaviours becomes more sophisticated. The company is focusing on offering a wide assortment of marquee international brands online and retail stores across the country.

**Ebola vaccines inch towards trials with new funding**

**Bloomberg**

Vaccine developers and funders are pushing forward with three experimental shots against the Ebola strain that's spreading in central Africa.

The Coalition for Epidemic Preparedness Innovations, or CEPI, said it is committing \$61.8 million to fund three vaccine candidates.

One is being developed by IAVI, the second by Moderna Inc and the third by the University of Oxford, with production by the Serum Institute of India. CEPI said it is still open to additional promising candidates.

Lack of an effective vac-

cine is complicating efforts against the outbreak of the Bundibugyo form of Ebola.

Its geographic footprint expanded on Monday to 22 affected zones across three eastern provinces in the Democratic Republic of Congo, from the 13 reported just days earlier.

**'EXTENDED OUTBREAK'**

The potential vaccines use different technologies, something CEPI said would maximise the likelihood of success. Each of the platforms has already been used to develop vaccine candidates that have shown promise in lab or human tests against viruses related to the Bundibugyo form of Ebola.

"My expectation is we need the vaccines for this outbreak and that we will deliver vaccines in time for them to be deployed into this outbreak and we will need them to bring this outbreak under control," CEPI Chief Executive Officer Richard Hatchett said in an interview. He added that most informed observers expect this to be a "very extended outbreak".

IAVI's candidate is deemed the "most promising," according to experts brought together by the World Health Organization. It uses the same development platform as Merck's already approved vaccine for a different strain of Ebola.

**Screenless wristbands gain traction for distraction-free health tracking**

**Sindhu Hariharan**  
Chennai

Increasing health awareness and growing consumer interest in distraction-free devices is making screenless wrist wearables a fast-growing sub-segment within India's wearables market, and generating significant interest among consumers.

While smartwatches still dominate India's wrist-worn wearables market, screenless fitness bands focused on health and wellness tracking are seeing more takers.

**EMERGING SEGMENT**

India's screenless band market, which currently accounts for 5 per cent of the total global screenless market and less than 1 per cent of the India wearables market, is expected to grow 2X in the

**FITNESS PUSH**

- Screenless bands make up less than 1% of India's wearables market, but are estimated to double over the next few years
- Whoop, Polar, Pebble and Amazfit among leading brands, with Google Fitbit Air being a recent entrant
- Most purchases are currently through online channels
- Influencer endorsements and awareness about sleep health are aiding the category's popularity

next couple of years, Tarun Pathak, Research Director, Counterpoint Research, said. Currently, the majority of the purchases are happening on the online channel in India, he adds.

Whoop, Polar, Pebble and Amazfit are among the top screenless wristband makers. The recent launch of Google Fitbit Air has also piqued consumer interest in

this category, and users are also drawn by the distraction-free experience that these screenless wristbands offer.

Anshika Jain, Principal Analyst, Counterpoint, said that increasing focus on recovery, better wearing experience, increased battery life due to lack of display and reduction in distraction owing to lesser digitalisation are

among the key drivers of demand.

Vikas Sharma, Lead Analyst, Smart Wearable Devices, IDC India, said such wristbands are helping the overall wrist-worn wearables category make a comeback after a period of lull. "New form factors, advanced health and fitness tracking capabilities, and use cases such as recovery monitoring have renewed consumer interest," he said. Influencer endorsements and growing awareness around sleep have also helped create renewed interest in the category.

IDC anticipates that more Indian wearable brands will likely introduce new products in this segment and compete strongly with global brands.

Amit Khatri, Co-founder of lifestyle tech brand Noise,

noted that the future of wearables is not more screens but more intelligence. "Consumers are increasingly looking for technology that fits naturally into their lives rather than constantly demanding their attention. This is driving interest in new form factors, such as smart rings and screen-less bands that prioritise comfort, continuous sensing and wellness insights," he said.

Noise did not disclose whether they are working on screenless variants.

However, screenless wrist wearables are not cannibalising the smartwatch market yet. "The key point to note here is that these screenless bands can be seen as complementary wearables and not as alternatives to smartwatches," Jain said.







